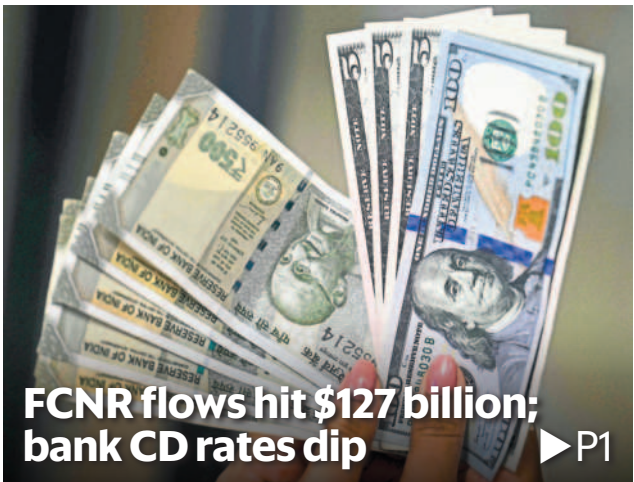


Thursday, September 3, 2026

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Listing pops back as IPO
Street lights up ▶ P1



FCNR flows hit \$127 billion;
bank CD rates dip ▶ P1



*EMPOWERING INDIANS
TO PARTICIPATE IN INDIA'S SUCCESS STORY*
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Thursday, September 3, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why jewellery giants are racing to consolidate

BY NEETHI LISA ROJAN

On Monday, GRT Jewellers India decided to acquire a 74.12% stake in listed jewellery retailer Tribhovandas Bhimji Zaveri, known as TBZ The Original, from its promoters for ₹1,033.71 crore. The deal reflects a shift towards a more organized, competitive sector. *Mint* explains:



1 What has triggered the wave of consolidation?

Jewellers are using acquisitions to plug strategic gaps. Chennai-based GRT, for instance, has historically been concentrated in southern India. Acquiring TBZ gives it access to 37 showrooms, most in western India. Senco Gold approved an investment of ₹68 crore to acquire a 68% stake in August Jewellery in January, strengthening its digital and omnichannel presence. P N Gadgil Jewellers approved the acquisition of Silvostyle Jewellers for ₹27.96 crore in August, adding to its silver jewellery offering. In July 2025, Titan Co. acquired a 67% stake in Dubai-based Damas Jewellery for its international expansion.

MINT

2 Is the jewellery market formalizing?

Yes. The organized segment's share has nearly doubled to 40-45% of the roughly ₹8.5 trillion jewellery market in FY26, from 20-25% in FY19, showed an 11 August Motilal Oswal Financial Services report. Organized jewellers have largely grown by taking customers from the unorganized market, aided by mandatory BIS hallmarking since July 2021. The shift towards formalization is also reflected in the growing number of jewellers tapping the stock markets. Lalitha Jewellery and B2B player Augmont Enterprises listed in August, while Priority Jewels is eyeing a 4 September debut. Deepa Jewellers' public offer opened on Tuesday.

3 Where is the sector expanding?

Organized jewellers are moving deeper into smaller cities. Retailers increased their store count to nearly 2,800 in June from around 2,050 in June 2024, up about 17% annually, according to Motilal Oswal. Smaller cities accounted for about 68% of the new stores added. The top 10 states still account for about 75% of organized jewellery stores.

4 How are retailers premiumizing?

Jewellers are steering customers towards higher-value products, particularly studded jewellery, which commands higher making charges and margins. Kalyan Jewellers' studded jewellery mix rose to 29% in QIFY27 from 20% in QIFY22. Titan has kept the mix in the mid-20s, while it is 10-11% for Senco Gold and P N Gadgil. Light-weight jewellery is another growth area as younger consumers buy jewellery for daily wear. CaratLane posted about 40% revenue CAGR between FY22 and FY26, while Candere recorded about 30%.

5 What policies are driving formalization?

Regulation is pushing the sector towards greater transparency and consumer protection. Hallmarking of silver jewellery is set to become mandatory from October, *Mint* reported on 31 August. The Centre had also raised gold and silver import tariffs to 15% in May. Higher tariffs, however, have not reduced gold imports. Reports show the Centre may be weighing rolling the rates back to 6%. Meanwhile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has urged Indians to avoid leisure trips abroad, weddings overseas and unnecessary gold purchases.

QUICK EDIT

A dollar deluge

The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) window to attract foreign currency deposits that saw shutters drop on 31 August, one month ahead of the initial schedule, has brought in a flood of dollars. RBI on Wednesday said that as much as \$127.2 billion has been collected by banks as forex deposits. A further \$9.2 billion came in through overseas foreign currency and external commercial borrowings, which remain open, taking total inflows since the mop-up began to \$136.4 billion. RBI's forex reserves have bulged as a result, having recently hit a record \$729 billion, and while excess liquidity has been something of a challenge, India's central bank is better placed to contain rupee volatility in case the currency suffers the fallout of balance-of-payments stress. A rupee slump has been a put-off for foreign investors in Indian assets, with their dollar returns eroded by its weakness. A focus on the exchange rate, however, interferes with monetary policy. For this reason, if not the cost RBI may eventually have to bear for the forex-risk hedge it granted deposit-taking banks, no one should miss the scheme that just ended. Except, perhaps, overseas Indians who got a splendid chance to make gains.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

There is a global contribution behind climate change. And the responsibility to manage and minimize its effects also rests on the global community.

BALENDRA SHAH
PRIME MINISTER, NEPAL



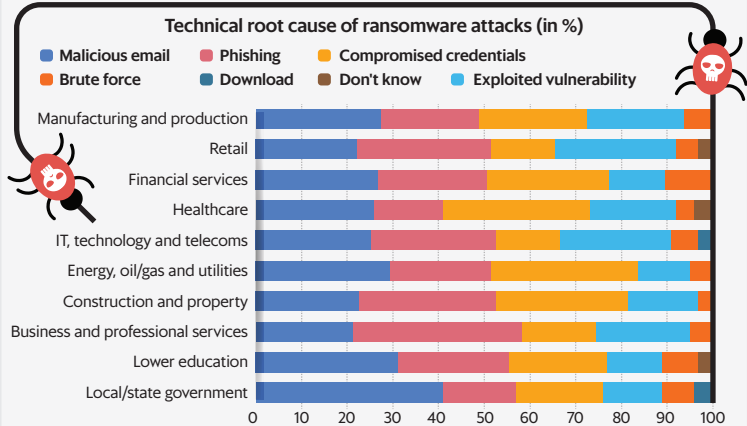
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- Views | Personal guarantees are back in India's limelight >P12
- Views | What the World Bank's B-Ready survey could tell us about India >P13

mint | DATA BITES

WHAT ARE THE COMMON RANSOMWARE ATTACKS?

Malicious emails and phishing lead ransomware attacks across most sectors, while compromised credentials drive nearly a third of attacks in distribution, healthcare and energy.



The survey was conducted in Jan-Mar 2026 and covered 2158 IT and cybersecurity decision-makers from organizations hit by ransomware in previous 12 months across 17 countries, including 240 respondents in India. Sectors with large sample sizes have been shown. Figures may not add up to 100% due to rounding.

Data: Rupanjal Chauhan
Graphic: Deepak Mishra

Source: Sophos State of Ransomware 2026

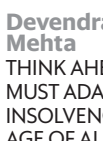
COLUMNS



DAVID FICKLING
THE NEPAL TRAGEDY
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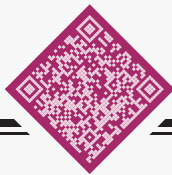


Anurag Behar
WE HAVE FEWER
STATE-RUN SCHOOLS
BUT THAT'S NO CAUSE
FOR ANY ALARM >P12



Devendra Mehta
THINK AHEAD: WE
MUST ADAPT
INSOLVENCY TO THE
AGE OF AI >P13





ECONOMY RESILIENT IN JULY, BUT RISKS LOOM

BY PAYAL BHATTACHARYA

India's July economic indicators showed resilience driven by vehicle sales and credit, but persistent inflation, uneven consumption, and monsoon deficits threaten rural demand.

MINT MACRO TRACKER

Launched in October 2018, Mint's macro tracker provides a monthly comprehensive report on the state of the economy, based on trends in 16 high-frequency indicators. For each indicator, the value in each month is assigned a colour-coding to denote where it lies relative to the one-year average range. In July 2026, seven of the 16 indicators were worse than their one-year average trend and nine better or in line, reflecting slight improvement compared to the previous month when eight indicators were worse than the average.

Performance relative to 1-year average range

Worse In line Better

	Consumer economy				Producer economy			
	Passenger car & van sales (y-o-y change, %)	Tractor sales (y-o-y change, %)	Broadband subscriber base (y-o-y change, %)	Domestic air passengers (y-o-y change, %)	PMI composite (values)	Core sector (y-o-y change, %)	Banks' non-food credit (y-o-y change, %)	Rail freight traffic (y-o-y change, %)
Feb 2026	-3.3	34.2	12.2	0.2	58.9	3.2	15.2	4.0
Mar 2026	6.9	29.1	12.9	-0.9	57.0	2.9	16.9	NA
Apr 2026	30.7	26.8	13.8	-3.5	58.2	2.7	16.3	NA
May 2026	26.3	19.6	10.8	9.5	59.3	3.2	17.4	1.3
Jun 2026	15.3	11.9	11.0	-1.0	57.1	6.0	18.3	4.0
Jul 2026	34.9	20.5	11.2	-4.8	54.3	5.4	19.1	9.0

	External sector				Ease of living			
	Import cover (FX reserves in months)	Rupee vs dollar (m-o-m change, %)	Labour-intensive exports (y-o-y change, %)	Trade balance (as % of total trade)	CPI inflation (y-o-y, %)	Core CPI inflation (y-o-y, %)	Real rural wages* (y-o-y change, %)	Labour force participation rate (in %)
Feb 2026	10.8	0.1	-0.8	-27.0	3.2	3.3	13.6	41.7
Mar 2026	10.6	-2.3	-22.8	-21.0	3.4	3.3	12.9	41.0
Apr 2026	10.5	-0.7	-7.2	-24.4	3.5	3.3	12.5	42.0
May 2026	10.0	-2.0	-1.8	-23.8	3.9	3.7	11.7	41.5
Jun 2026	9.7	0.6	12.1	-27.4	4.4	4.1	NA	41.4
Jul 2026	10.0	-0.9	-3.7	-26.5	4.5	4.0	NA	42.2

All data as of 2 September 2026. If data is not available for the latest two months, the previous available figure has been used for colour coding. The worse/better colour coding is reversed for inflation. *Double digit growth is due to wage revision from July 2025.

Source: CMIE, Bloomberg, Mint calculations



India's economic scorecard improved marginally in July, with nine of 16 indicators tracked by *Mint* above or in line with their one-year average, up from eight in June. Yet seven indicators, ranging from domestic air travel to inflation, remained below their one-year average, pointing to continued weakness across parts of the economy. *Mint*'s macro tracker provides a monthly snapshot based on 16 high-frequency indicators, each colour-coded according to its position relative to its one-year average range.

The July improvement was led by a higher labour force participation rate, along with stronger vehicle sales, bank credit and rail freight, while broadband growth remained steady. But domestic air travel contracted for a second month, labour-intensive exports turned negative after a sharp June recovery, the rupee depreciated against the dollar and consumer inflation rose.

The July reading, therefore, points to modest improvement rather than broad-based strengthening. The divergence is particularly clear between goods and services consumption, and between domestic production and the external sector. Passenger vehicle and tractor sales recovered from their June slowdown, while air traffic weakened further. Rail freight and bank credit strengthened even as the composite purchasing managers' index moderated further.

CONSUMPTION REGAINS PACE

Consumption indicators improved in July after a broad moderation in June. Passenger car and van sales growth surged to 34.9% year-on-year from 15.3% in June, reversing three consecutive months of slowing growth. Tractor sales also recovered, with growth rising to 20.5% from 11.9%. Broadband subscriber growth edged up to 11.2% from 11%.

The improvement, however, was not broad-based. Domestic air passenger traffic contracted 4.8% year-on-year in July, following a 1% contraction in June and 9.5% growth in May. The continued weakness contrasts with the recovery in vehicle sales, leaving consumption uneven.

Production indicators were firmer. Rail freight growth accelerated to 9% in July from 4% in June, while banks' outstanding non-food credit growth rose to 19.1% from 18.3%. Core-sector growth moderated to 5.4% from 6% in June but remained above the 3.2% recorded in May. The composite PMI, however, continued to lose momentum, falling to 54.3 in July from 57.1 in June and 59.3 in May. It remained above the 50-mark indicating expansion, but the third consecutive monthly decline suggests stronger production indicators have not translated into broader business momentum. Taken together, the July data points to stronger goods consumption and freight activity, while services demand and the broader business activity gauge remained weaker.

RENEWED PRESSURE POINTS

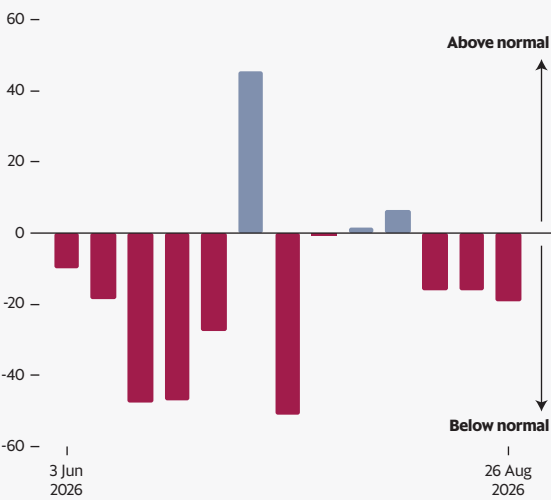
The improvement comes with a fresh complication: inflation is beginning to rise just as some consumption indicators recover.

Food and beverages inflation is estimated to have risen to 5.7% in August from 5.2% in July, according to IDFC First Bank Economics Research, driven by proteins, edible oils, ready-made products and sugar. Vegetable inflation is expected to moderate despite localized pressure in onions, while tomato prices have eased. The broader increase is therefore not simply a temporary vegetable-price shock.

This matters because food accounts for a large share of

After July reprieve, rainfall turned deficient again in August, keeping farm risks alive

Deviation from normal (in %) for the week ended...



Source: CMIE



household spending. A larger food bill could absorb gains from stronger vehicle sales and other consumption, particularly for households with limited discretionary income, making inflation a key risk to the recovery in domestic demand.

THE TOUGHER TEST

The bigger risk lies beyond August's inflation print. With about 97% of kharif sowing completed by 28 August, the focus is shifting to crop performance. Total acreage was 1.7% below last year, with rice and coarse cereals down 3.4% and 2.3%, respectively. Pulses were up 1.2%, while oilseeds were down 0.5%. The small gap in total acreage masks greater vulnerability in crops with lower irrigation coverage. Rice, with about 65% irrigation coverage, is better insulated from rainfall shortages than pulses, oilseeds and coarse cereals. A weak monsoon could therefore hurt parts of the crop basket even if aggregate sowing remains close to last year.

Rainfall weakened sharply in August, which was 15% below normal after July's 1% surplus, leaving cumulative monsoon rainfall 13% below normal as of 28 August, according to the weather office. The shortfall was concentrated in states accounting for 31% of foodgrain production, including Bihar, Andhra Pradesh, Punjab, Karnataka and Rajasthan; another 66% received normal to excess rainfall.

Reservoir storage was 67.8% of live capacity as of 27 August, below both last year and the 10-year average. Low storage could also constrain rabi irrigation, extending agricultural pressure into the next sowing season.

The weather outlook offers little relief. Skymet expects September rainfall to be 20% below normal and has cut its 2026 monsoon forecast to a 15% deficit. El Niño conditions are expected to strengthen in early September.

That puts rural demand at risk just as urban and goods consumption are recovering. Rating agency Icria Ltd has cautioned that a weaker monsoon could hit crop output and farm incomes, while higher retail inflation could constrain discretionary spending.



MINT SHORTS

Russia says no more hurdles in payments with India

Moscow: Russia and India, the second-largest importer of Russian oil, have built a functioning payments infrastructure using roubles and rupees, which now account for 96% of bilateral trade, a senior Russian banker said on Wednesday. Russia's trade with India reached a record \$70 billion in 2024, tripling since the start of the conflict in Ukraine in 2022, as India stepped up imports of Russian oil discounted due to Western sanctions. **REUTERS**

Sitharaman meets Russian counterpart Siluanov



Washington: Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman met her Russian counterpart Anton Siluanov and discussed strengthening bilateral cooperation and establishing the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Development Bank. The two ministers met on the sidelines of the G20 Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors (FMCBG) Meeting in Asheville on Monday. **PTI**

India's diaspora deposit flows surpass \$100 billion: report

Inflows under the Reserve Bank of India's special overseas deposit facility have topped the \$100 billion mark, the *Financial Express* newspaper reported Wednesday, citing officials it did not identify. The massive dollar inflow has pushed up RBI's reserves to a record high of \$729.3 billion and helped avert what could have been an unprecedented third year of a deficit in India's measure of money flowing in and out of the economy. **BLOOMBERG**

India urged to review green finance rules to meet 2047 goal



New Delhi: India needs to review some of its financing rules and develop a stronger talent pipeline to achieve its ambitious goal of expanding nuclear power capacity to 100GW by 2047, officials and industry executives said on Wednesday. India's sovereign green bond framework, green deposit and financing rules need to be reviewed as they currently do not cover nuclear investments, said Abhay Karandikar, a member of NITI Aayog. **REUTERS**

Imports of soy oil at record in August, palm oil at six-month high

Mumbai: Indian refiners imported a record amount of soy oil in August and the highest volume of palm oil in six months as they built stocks ahead of the festival season, five dealers said. Higher palm oil and soy oil buying by the world's biggest importer of vegetable oils could help top producers Indonesia, Malaysia and Argentina bring down stocks and support benchmark palm oil and soy oil futures. **REUTERS**

Pakistan urges India to engage constructively on Indus treaty

Islamabad: Pakistan on Wednesday urged India to engage with it constructively within the framework of the Indus Water Treaty that both countries solemnly accepted. Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi made the remarks days after India rejected the Permanent Court of Arbitration's order setting aside its decision to suspend the IWT with Pakistan. He said that Pakistan is committed to implementing the treaty. **PTI**

India offers help to rebuild Nepal's hydropower, infra

State-run hydropower majors NHPC and SJVN have offered technical assistance to Nepal

Rituraj Baruah & Subhash Narayan
NEW DELHI

India has offered to help Nepal get its hydropower plants, roads and bridges back on their feet after devastating floods and landslides ravaged critical infrastructure across the Himalayan country, according to three officials aware of the developments. They said state-run hydropower majors NHPC Ltd and SJVN Ltd have offered technical assistance towards the effort, deepening New Delhi's role in rebuilding infrastructure in the country, where it is already a major energy partner.

Around 700MW of hydropower capacity have been knocked out, while key roads and bridges have been washed away by the floods on 26 August. Over 1,100 people have been reported killed by the floods, while over 4,800 people are still missing. "The Centre and the hydro PSUs have assured that they can provide technical assistance to restore the damaged hydro power projects in Nepal. It would, however, depend upon the Nepalese authorities' decision on the matter," said an official in the know of the development.

Queries emailed to the ministries of power, road transport & highways and external affairs, the hydropower firms, and Embassy of Nepal in New Delhi remained unanswered until



As collaborative efforts are already on for relief measures, support for infra redevelopment and restoration of power projects has also been assured. **PTI**

press time.

Indian companies already have a presence in several large hydropower projects of Nepal, including SJVN's 900MW Arun-III and 679MW Lower Arun projects, and NHPC's 1,200MW West Seti and Seti River-6 joint project and 480MW Phukot Karnali project. The GMR Group is also developing the 900MW Upper Karnali project.

India is also a major market for Nepal's surplus electricity, with cross-border power trade becoming an increasingly important component of bilateral economic ties.

"The ministry of external affairs is in

constant touch with the Nepalese government. As collaborative efforts are already on for relief measures, support for infrastructure redevelopment and restoration of power projects has also been assured. The immediate focus is on relief and rescue," said another official.

Hitendra Dev Shakya, former managing director of the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) told *Mint* that the focus is now on relief and rescue of the affected people, and in due course studies would be done to get details of the damage to power projects.

"Studies will have to be done to know

where sludge has accumulated, or where turbines have been displaced. Only after that will restoration work start," Shakya said. He identified the 24MW Trishuli and 14.1MW Devghat hydropower plants, both built with Indian assistance, as potential candidates for Indian support.

Power availability itself is not an immediate crisis, he said. Of Nepal's installed capacity of about 4,300MW, around 3,600MW remains operational, against a peak domestic requirement of roughly 2,600MW.

Some experts called for regional cooperation to bring sustainable security in the Himalayan region, which is highly vulnerable to natural disasters due to climate change. Indian National Hydropower Association president Abhay Kumar Singh called for a mechanism involving Nepal, India and China to assess risks from developments in upstream areas and formulate long-term safety measures for downstream regions.

India's experience in responding to infrastructure disasters in its own Himalayan states could also provide a basis for cooperation. "NHPC is well equipped to assist in restoration in such cases with efficiency," said Raj Kumar Chaudhary, former chairman and managing director of NHPC.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

700MW
Hydropower
capacity project
knocked out1,100
Number of people
reported killed by
the Nepal floods

Goyal will visit US to deepen trade ties

Manas Pimpalkhare
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NEW DELHI

Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal will visit the US at the end of this month for talks on the proposed trade agreement between the world's largest economy and the world's most populous nation, US ambassador to India Sergio Goro said on Wednesday.

Trade between the two Indian and US must deepen, Goro said at an event organized by the Automotive Component Manufacturers' Association of India (Acma) in the national capital. "Our two governments are working closely together to build a trade relationship that is fair, reciprocal, and mutually beneficial. And I don't know if this is public yet, but minister Goyal will be travelling at the end of the month to the United States to continue engaging as we

host the G20 talks," Goro said. India and the US launched negotiations for a Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) in February 2025, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Donald Trump formally announced the talks. The deal is yet to be finalized. Bilateral trade between the two countries stood at \$140.76 billion in fiscal year 2026.

Goro said the US and India are also working together

Goro said the US and India are working together across a range of areas, including critical minerals and technology

the Pax Silica declaration, a landmark step towards a pro-innovation regulatory framework. This declaration will make it easier for Indian and American companies to invest across borders and power next generation of entrepreneurs."

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Government defends GDP estimates

Banikinkar Pattanayak & Subhash Narayan

NEW DELHI

The government on Wednesday defended its methodology for estimating national income and the June-quarter growth rate, saying revisions to 2025-26 GDP and divergence between price gauges reflect updated data and methods, rather than an attempt to mechanically inflate the figures.

The ministry of statistics and programme implementation (MoSPI) issued a detailed clarification in a question-and-answer format, refuting allegations of artificially pushing up the real growth rate for the three months through June to 7.8% and the nominal expansion rate to 10.3%.

The statistics ministry on 31 August released an updated series of annual and quarterly GDP estimates, with 2022-23 as the base year, and rolled out a new Producer Price Index, Banking Services Price Index, and additional administrative data.

The ministry said the nominal GDP for the first quarter of 2026-27 was initially esti-



The Centre said revisions to 2025-26 GDP and divergence between price gauges reflect updated data and methods. **ISTOCKPHOTO**

mated at ₹86.05 trillion under the old 2011-12 base-year series. Following the introduction of the new GDP series with 2022-23 as the base year in February 2026, the estimate was revised to ₹80.32 trillion, and subsequently to ₹80.44 trillion on 5 June based on the latest data.

Once the new series for the Index of Industrial Production and the Producer Price Index became available, the nominal GDP

estimate was revised to ₹80 trillion.

"Thus, the movement from ₹86.05 trillion to ₹80.00 trillion is the result

of successive revisions to the GDP series arising from the change in the base year, incorporation of improved data sources and methodologies, and updation of

available indicators," the ministry said. "It is therefore incorrect to interpret the difference as a deliberate downward revi-

JCR upgrades credit rating of India to A-

Subhash Narayan
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NEW DELHI

Japan Credit Rating Agency Ltd (JCR) on Wednesday upgraded India's sovereign credit rating by a notch to A- from BBB+, citing the economy's sustained high growth, the effectiveness of its economic policies, stronger financial system and improving quality of government expenditure.

JCR had maintained the BBB+ rating for India since 2007, including during the global financial crisis, the pandemic, and subsequent geopolitical disruptions.

The agency also raised the country ceiling by one notch to A, reflecting its assessment that India's economic fundamentals, policy framework, fiscal trajectory and financial-sector resilience have strengthened sufficiently to warrant a higher sovereign credit standing.

It assigned a stable outlook to both India's foreign-currency and local-currency long-term issuer ratings.

The upgrade comes as India continues to retain its position as the fastest-growing major economy, expanding at a high pace despite a turbulent global environment marked by geopolitical conflicts, and elevated energy prices.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

India plans to curb the diversion of legal chemicals into illicit drugs

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NEW DELHI

India plans to introduce a voluntary code of conduct for precursor chemicals—essential raw materials for legal medicines and industrial goods—to prevent their diversion from legitimate uses to illicit drug manufacturing, two officials aware of the matter said, citing official documents.

The framework, being developed by the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) under the home affairs ministry in consultation with the Indian Drug Manufacturers Associa-

tion (IDMA), covers chemical producers, pharmaceutical firms, logistics providers, exporters, and regulatory bodies. The dual-use nature of precursor chemicals makes them vulnerable to diversion by illicit drug networks.

The proposed code seeks to plug this vulnerability by placing the onus on companies and other supply-chain participants to track shipments, verify buyers, audit inventories, and flag suspicious transactions, while the government seeks tighter controls without imposing new statutory compliance requirements.

The framework covers



The dual-use nature of precursor chemicals makes them vulnerable to diversion by illicit drug networks. **MINT**

scheduled and non-scheduled dual-use precursor chemicals, including hydrochloric acid, acetone, pseudoephedrine,

sodium hydroxide, methylene chloride, ethanol, toluene, red phosphorus, and ethyl acetate. "Effective precursor control

cannot rely on enforcement alone. Industry, trade, transporters, warehouse operators, importers, exporters, and end-users constitute the first line of defence against diversion," the NCB document stated.

The objective is not to impose additional compliance burdens on legitimate businesses, but to build a collaborative framework that balances security with ease of doing business, one of the officials cited above said.

Queries to the health and family welfare ministry, NCB, and IDMA on 1 August remained unanswered till press time.

Industry executives said drug manufacturers already maintain strict documentation protocols for regulatory compliance and pharmacovigilance or drug safety.

Hari Kiran Chereddi, managing director and chief executive at Hyderabad-based HRV Pharma, said the industry is prepared for the voluntary measures. "The pharmaceutical industry has long faced challenges due to the lack of oversight. The same chemicals used to make legal medicines can be misused to manufacture illegal drugs," Chereddi said. "A voluntary code that includes tracking

shipments, inventory checks to verify buyers, and reporting suspicious activity is a welcome step. Most manufacturers already maintain these records for regulators."

The key to making this work is coordination. "NCB and IDMA must agree on reporting data in formats that match what companies currently use, so compliance does not become additional work. When done right, it strengthens trust in the pharma supply chain without adding unnecessary documentation burdens," he said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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MINT SHORTS

JM Financial garners ₹700 crore from maiden pre-IPO fund

New Delhi: JM Financial Asset Management Ltd on Wednesday said it has secured ₹700 crore in the first close of its pre-IPO (initial public offering) fund, which will focus on investing in businesses expected to pursue a public listing within 18 months. JM Financial India Pre-IPO Fund was launched with a target corpus of ₹1,500 crore and a green shoe option of up to ₹1,000 crore. The fund has received commitments from a range of investors, including ultra-high-net-worth individuals, family offices and institutional investors.

PTI

Nvidia's Jensen Huang urges G20 to speed up AI adoption



AFP

Nvidia Corp. chief executive officer Jensen Huang called on Group of 20 nations to accelerate their adoption of artificial intelligence as a way to enhance growth, urging the world's largest economies to expand data centres and other infrastructure to support the emerging technology. "Every single country needs to build infrastructure so you can support your own local economy," Huang said on Wednesday at a tech event in North Carolina hosted by the US for G20 members.

BLOOMBERG

Simple Energy eyes big fundraise to enhance production capacity

Bengaluru: IPO-bound electric two-wheeler maker Simple Energy is in "works" with a large fundraise to secure funds as it looks more capital for enhancing production capacity and in supply chain, company's founder and chief executive officer Suhas Rajkumar has said. "We are in works with a very large fundraiser," Rajkumar told PTI on the sidelines of the launch of its first family scooter Wave on Wednesday.

PTI

E-commerce market to hit \$345 bn by 2030; dark stores to triple

New Delhi: The e-commerce sector is projected to grow nearly three times to \$345 billion by 2030 from \$125 billion in 2024, propelled by the rapid quick commerce expansion and artificial intelligence integration, as per a report released on Wednesday. As per the report, the market is expected to grow at a compound annual growth rate of 18.4% through 2030.

PTI

Indian companies may raise over \$20 bn in IPOs this year

About 58 firms have raised ₹73,757 crore so far this year, led by SBI Funds' ₹9,813 crore IPO

Priyamvada C & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

India's equity capital markets could see a little over \$20 billion worth of initial public offerings (IPOs) by the end of this year, driven by robust activity across primary issuances and secondary trades, and a busy near-term transaction pipeline, according to a top executive at Avendus Capital.

About 58 companies have raised ₹73,757 crore (close to \$8 billion) so far this year, with SBI Funds raising the most (around ₹9,813 crore or \$1.03 billion) followed by Manipal Hospitals (around ₹9,275.22 crore or \$960 million), according to data from Prime Database.

Mint reported previously that 103 companies raised about \$21 billion from IPOs in 2025, surpassing the record set in 2024, when 91 companies raised \$18 billion.

"Across the broader equity market, we are seeing strong activity in both primary issuances and secondary trades with an active pipeline of companies looking to tap the public markets over the next quarter," said Gaurav Sood, managing director and head of equity capital markets (ECM) at Avendus Capital, adding that two or three mega-issuance companies are expected to contribute the bulk of the \$20-billion figure.

Public markets have staged a strong recovery over the past two months, buoyed by recent listings including Manipal Hospitals, Leap India, SBI Funds Management, Dhoot Transmissions, and Milky Mist. Momentum is set to build further with highly anticipated offerings from NSE (about \$3 billion) and Jio Platforms (about \$3.8 billion to \$4 billion).

This comes as India recorded a four-fold increase in the number of companies listing at an issue size exceeding \$200 million in the past two years,



As many as 103 companies raised about \$21 billion from IPOs in 2025. ISTOCKPHOTO

according to Sood. He noted that public offerings in the \$200-500 million bracket are surging, while investor acceptance for massive \$1-5 billion-plus IPOs has also grown significantly. This momentum is set to persist, fueled by deepening domestic markets with

transactions spanning IPOs, qualified institutional placements (QIPs), block sales, and pre-IPO fundraises over the last four years.

Its IPO advisory track record includes Lenskart, SEDEMAC, Firstcry, Swiggy, Leap, Symbiotec Pharma-

CAPITAL RUSH

PUBLIC markets have staged a strong recovery over the past two months

MOMENTUM is set to build further with highly anticipated offerings from NSE and Jio Platforms

INDIA saw fourfold increase in number of companies listing at an issue size exceeding \$200 mn

BUSINESS traction is strongest in new-age tech, Reits, InvITs, industrials, financials, healthcare

investors showing a higher propensity for newer business models on a path to profitability.

Avendus's equity capital markets franchise, built on the strong underwriting of its investment banking arm, has concluded over \$12 billion in total transaction value across more than 50

lab, Amagi, and ICICI Prudential AMC. In the real estate investment trust (REIT) and infrastructure investment trust (InvIT) space, it has advised Brookfield REIT, IndiGrid, Indus Infra Trust, NHIT and others.

The firm is also active in block deals and QIPs, having facilitated stake sales

Data centre profits surge as existing capacity gets utilized

Yadukrishna C S & Jas Bardia
MUMBAI/BENGALURU

Some of India's biggest data-centre operators are enjoying a rare combination: faster revenue growth and fatter margins. But the earnings boom for fiscal year 2026 (FY26) was driven less by artificial intelligence (AI) than by existing capacity filling up.

Bharti Airtel-owned Nxtra Data, AdaniConneX, Sify Infinit Spaces and IPO-bound ESDS Software Solutions reported strong revenue growth in FY26, according to a Mint review of company filings. All four reported their fastest revenue growth and strongest operating margins in at least three years. AdaniConneX and Nxtra also marked their sharpest operating-margin expansion in at least three years.

Together, the four account for more than a third of India's data-centre market, according to Anarock Capital.

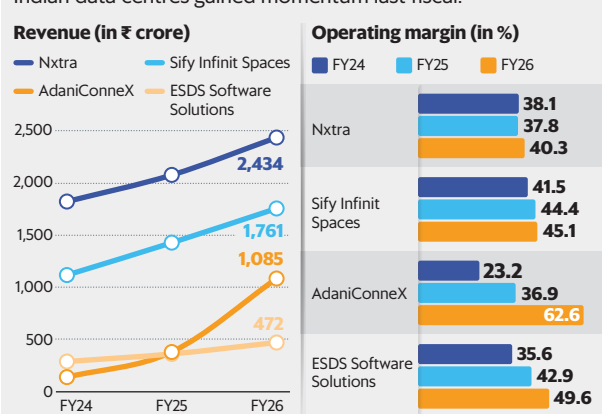
Four others—CtrlS Datacentres, STT Global Data Centres India, NTT India and Yotta Data Services—also reported higher revenue growth in FY25, but have yet to disclose their FY26 earnings.

The performance comes amid a broader expansion in India's data-centre industry, driven by rising cloud adoption, data localization and the growing computing demands of AI. Over the past year, domestic conglomerates, global technology companies including Google, Amazon, Microsoft and Meta, and standalone operators have committed more than \$250 billion to new data centre capacity in India, according to a Mint analysis of investment announcements made.

"FY26's high revenue and profitability come from capacity built in the last cycle reaching utilization, rather than from

Data boom

Indian data centres gained momentum last fiscal.



Source: Company financials, corporate affairs ministry

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

AI workloads," said Sanchit Vir Goghia, chief executive officer (CEO) of technology advisory firm Greyhound Research. "AI is becoming an important source of incremental demand, but it is not yet the main driver of current revenues," said Kashyap Kompella, analyst and founder of technology consultancy firm RPA2AI Research. "Most current earnings continue to come from cloud, enterprise, BFSI, telecom, digital content and other conventional workloads."

Nxtra's revenue jumped 17.1% year-on-year to ₹2,434 crore in FY26, its fastest growth in three years, helped by capacity expansion. In March, it raised \$1 billion from Alpha Wave of AI. Over the past year, domestic conglomerates, global technology companies including Google, Amazon, Microsoft and Meta, and standalone operators have committed more than \$250 billion to new data centre capacity in India, according to a Mint analysis of investment announcements made.

"FY26's high revenue and profitability come from capacity built in the last cycle reaching utilization, rather than from

"With hyperscalers and

small clients alike expanding rapidly, there is ample opportunity to capture customers, even though the market is competitive," CEO Sharad Agarwal told Mint on 11 August.

AdaniConneX, the joint venture between Adani Enterprises and EQT-backed EdgeConneX, reported revenue of ₹1,084 crore, its fastest growth in two years. It aims to develop 2GW of renewable-powered data-centre capacity by 2030 to "meet the surging demand for Data Center infrastructure and solutions," according to its FY26 annual report.

ESDS Software Solutions, which is eyeing a listing, reported a 30.7% jump in revenue to ₹472.2 crore. More than two-thirds of its incremental revenue came from a single client that contributed about ₹75 crore, according to its exchange filings. Experts also attributed the growth to rising demand for data sovereignty.

Earlier, most hyperscalers like Microsoft and Google invested in data centres but since there has been a need to store India's data within India, more companies are investing in data centres to store local data within the country, said Amit Chandra, vice-president, HDFC Securities.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Google defeats US bid to force ad tech sale

Reuters
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Alphabet's Google escaped a breakup of its advertising technology business on Wednesday, when a judge in Virginia rejected US antitrust enforcers' bid to force a sale of Google's online advertising exchange.

While the ad exchange is a small part of Google's business, the ruling is the second powerful symbolic victory against the US Department of Justice (DOJ) in its efforts to force Google to sell assets to address illegal monopolies.

US Judge Leonie Brinkema in Alexandria, Virginia, declined to make Google sell AdX, where publishers pay Google a 20% fee to sell ads in auctions that happen instantly when users load websites. She accepted most of the parties' proposed behavioural remedies. The DOJ and a broad coalition of states sued Google in 2023 over its dominance in markets for advertising technology used by online publishers and websites.

In April 2025, Brinkema ruled that Google holds illegal monopolies on servers that host publisher ads and ad exchanges which sit between buyers and sellers. Google unlawfully locked publishers on its ad server into using its AdX, the judge found.

The tech giant's anticompetitive conduct "substantially harmed Google's publisher customers, the competitive process, and, ultimately, consumers of information on the open web," Brinkema said at the time. At a trial last year on remedies in the case, the DOJ argued that Google cannot be trusted to run AdX, given its past behaviour. Google argued that a forced sale would be technically difficult and result in a long and painful transition that would hurt customers.

La Caisse buys 24% in Altius for ₹12,100 cr

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MUMBAI

Canadian investment group La Caisse will invest about ₹12,100 crore for a 24% stake in Brookfield-owned Altius Telecom Infrastructure Trust, India's largest independent telecom tower platform, the companies said in a statement on Wednesday.

Brookfield is Altius' largest investor, alongside La Caisse and other shareholders affiliated with GIC and British Columbia Investment Management Corp (BCI).

India is the world's second-largest telecom market, while rising mobile data use and 5G adoption are driving demand for digital infrastructure.

"As India's economy grows and more people and businesses rely on higher use of mobile data, the infrastructure behind the connections needs to keep pace," said Emmanuel Jaclot, executive vice president and head, infrastructure and sustainability, La Caisse.

"This is a sector we know well through our investments in telecom towers and digital infrastructure globally. With Altius, we are investing in an attractive market through an established platform alongside Brookfield and other institutional partners with whom we have longstanding relationship," he added.

La Caisse, with over 60 years of investment experience, has interests across major financial markets, private equity, infrastructure, real estate and private credit. As of 30 June, it held CAD 552 billion in net assets.

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FIRESIDE CHAT



RAJESH AGRAWAL IAS

Secretary, Department of Commerce, Ministry of Commerce and Industry, GOI

THE CEO DIALOGUE



RAJIV MEMANI

Chairman & CEO, EY India



ATUL LALL

Vice Chairman & MD, Dixon Technologies

SPOTLIGHT CONVERSATION



JAN METZGER

Global Head, Coverage Banking, Standard Chartered



TARUN GARG

MD & CEO, Hyundai Motor India



P D SINGH

CEO, Standard Chartered, India & South Asia



DILIP SAWHNEY

MD, Rockwell Automation India

TODAY | 6:30 PM ONWARDS
LIVE ON / CNBC-TV18

BSE Sensex				Nifty 50				Nifty 500				Nifty Next 50				Nifty 100				BSE 150 MidCap				BSE 250 SmallCap			
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Auto sector is far from slowing

Manish Joshi
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Auto sales volumes for August have been impressive for most companies—except Hero MotoCorp. Shares of all auto companies except Tata Motors PV reacted negatively on Wednesday after an overnight escalation in the West Asia conflict, dragging the Nifty Auto index 1.8% lower.

Among two-wheeler companies, Hero MotoCorp's domestic sales volume growth was 4% year-on-year, much lower than that of its peers. TVS Motor Co.'s domestic sales volume growth was the highest at 18%. Bajaj Auto and Eicher Motors's Royal Enfield reported growth of 10% and 11%, respectively.

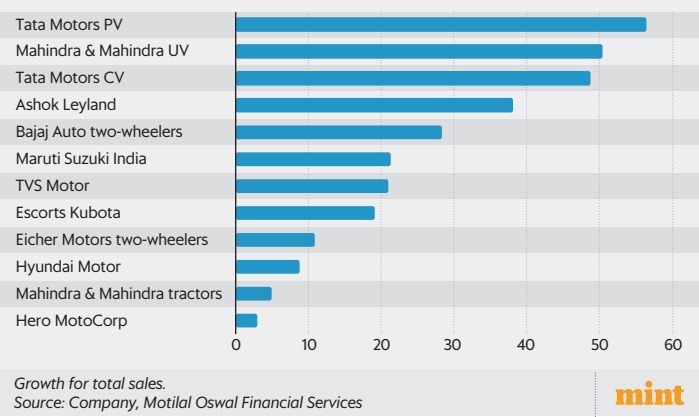
Among car companies, Maruti Suzuki India reported a 21% year-on-year growth in sales volumes. However, concerns were expressed on two fronts: a 7% year-on-year drop in exports and a 10% month-on-month drop in domestic passenger vehicle (PV) sales to 176,000 units.

Maruti's management clarified in

Monthly race

Tata group companies stand out on year-on-year volume growth in August on PVs and CVs; Hero's growth lags the entire sector.

Year-on-year growth for August sales volume (in %)



Growth for total sales.
Source: Company, Motilal Oswal Financial Services

interviews to the media that exports suffered because of the lack of ships, which now take a longer route around the Cape of Good Hope to skirt the conflict zone in West Asia. So, lower exports do not reflect a softening in demand. Maruti is confident of boosting exports in the future with a diversified base of more than

100 countries.

The 10% sequential drop in Maruti's domestic PV sales was driven more by a 17% decline in small cars, even as utility vehicle (UV) sales were little changed. Volumes in June were unusually low versus April and May due to price hike uncertainty. The underperformance of June was

made up in July, leading to a significantly high base for August in a month-on-month comparison.

The management also cited some supply-side constraints. Besides, the premium segment (with higher margins) sales in UVs have risen marginally month-on-month and have not

dropped. Among PV makers, Tata Motors performed the best with 59% year-on-year growth in domestic sales volumes.

But its investors give less weightage to monthly volume data as its stock price is more sensitive to developments in its UK subsidiary Jaguar Land Rover Automotive PLC.

Mahindra & Mahindra (M&M) was the second-best performer, with a 50% year-on-year jump in volumes. While Hyundai Motor India's domestic sales growth came in at 24%, weak exports and supply-side constraints, similar to those cited by Maruti, pulled down overall growth to 9%.

Tata Motors commercial vehicles

(CV) saw a 49% year-on-year volume growth to 44,400 vehicles, whereas its smaller rival Ashok Leyland reported 38% growth at 21,000 units. The strong sales growth data vindicates statements from CV makers that the average fleet age of 9-10 years needs replacement.

HIGH GEAR

IN August, industrial demand (CVs) was stronger than consumer demand (PVs, two-wheelers)

BUT it remains to be seen if the growth momentum continues on a high base of H2FY26

Among tractor companies, Escorts' sales growth at 19% year-on-year significantly outperformed M&M's 5%, but it has to be noted that the former has a lower base.

The key takeaway from August sales volume numbers for investors is that industrial demand (CVs) has been stronger than consumer demand (PVs and two-wheelers).

In the next couple of months, data is likely to be robust for most automakers as dispatches to dealers pick up ahead of the festival season. After that, it remains to be seen if the growth momentum continues on a high base of H2FY26, triggered by the cuts in the goods and services tax in September last year.

Shadow lenders line up ₹10,000 cr in rupee bonds

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India's shadow lenders are set to raise at least ₹10,000 crore (\$1.1 billion) through the issuance of local currency bonds as early as next week, according to people familiar with the matter, as they race to lock in borrowing costs before they rise further.

State-run Power Finance Corp. Ltd is seeking bids on Thursday for a two-part bond issuance to raise as much as ₹5,000 crore, after raising ₹2,500 crore via 15-year notes last week, the people said, asking not to be identified discussing private matters.

Bajaj Housing Finance Ltd, a unit of top financier Bajaj Finance Ltd, is planning to raise as much as ₹2,000 crore, while HDFC Bank Ltd's arm HDB Financial Services Ltd is planning to issue at least ₹1,000 crore worth of notes. Tata Capital Ltd is planning to borrow at least ₹1,500 crore, and Shriram Finance Ltd, the nation's biggest vehicle financier, is planning an over ₹500 crore offering.

Non-bank lenders are the biggest issuers of local currency bonds in India and they're rushing to raise funds as borrowing costs globally and at home increase.

A strong bond pipeline would boost rupee-denominated issuance that's down about 13% so far this year to ₹8.7 trillion, according to data compiled by Bloomberg.

Inflation risks brought on by rising oil prices have boosted expectations that the US Federal Reserve will raise rates. Faster than expected economic growth in India has also bolstered the chances of inter-



Non-bank lenders are the biggest issuers of local currency bonds in India. REUTERS

est-rate increases later this year.

The average yield on top-rated two-year and five-year corporate bonds issued by shadow lenders rose to 7.98% and 8.09%, respectively on Tuesday, the highest level in nearly three months, according to data compiled by Bloomberg. The three-year counterpart climbed 26 basis points last week, the most for a five-day period since the week ended 22 May.

A basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point.

"Issuers are lining up in the bond market as interest rates are set to rise," said Soumyajit Nyogi,

director at India Ratings, a local unit of Fitch Ratings. "The demand for funds from non-bank firms has increased also as they build liquidity to meet credit demand ahead of the festive season."

The Reserve Bank of India held its benchmark rate at 5.25% in August, though policymakers have signalled that a hike may be needed if price pressures build.

Citigroup expects 50-75 basis points in increases in the key rate between October and March.

PVR Inox's ₹300-crore buyback: on track for a comeback?

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PVR Inox's ₹300 crore buyback gave investors another reason to cheer. The stock is flat since Monday's announcement despite a decline in Nifty 50, taking its 2026 returns to almost 20%. Yet, the broader picture remains less cheery: the stock sits about 15% below its 2023 level, when PVR and Inox Leisure merged.

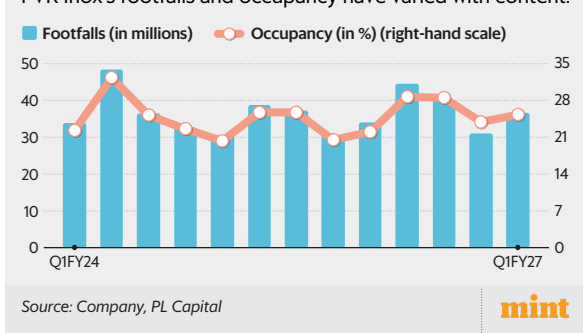
PVR Inox will buy back up to 2.11% of its paid-up equity capital at ₹1,450 per share, a 20% premium to its 31 August price. The promoters, who

own 27.53%, also intend to participate. According to JM Financial Institutional Securities, the buyback signals balance sheet confidence, as PVR transitioned from net debt of ₹162 crore at the end of March to net cash of ₹81 crore by the end of June.

Revenue and margins improved as well, helped by a strong movie slate including *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*, *Michael* and *Obsession*. Q1FY27 revenue rose 11.9% year-on-year to ₹1,622 crore, with footfalls up 7.6% to 36.6 million. The average ticket price rose 7.5% to ₹273, while food & beverage spending per

Choppy recovery

PVR Inox's footfalls and occupancy have varied with content.



Source: Company, PL Capital

head rose 8.8% to ₹161. Pre-Ind AS Ebitda margin, a measure of core operating profitability that deducts actual lease

rent expenses, expanded to 12.9%.

While management expects to add around 80 net screens

in FY27, 79% of these additions will follow the asset-light, franchise-owned company-operated model. So, the full-year capex guidance has been cut from ₹400 crore to ₹350 crore. Expansion into under-penetrated tier-II and III cities is slated to begin in FY28.

However, footfalls have been volatile, ranging from 30.4 million per quarter to 48.4 million in recent years, depending heavily on the festive season and the movie pipeline. PL Capital expects footfalls to compound at only 4.7% through FY28.

Occupancy improved to 25.3% in Q1FY27 versus last

year, though it still leaves enough room for growth. Continued cost control, capital-light expansion, and disciplined screen rationalization are expected to lift margins over FY27 and FY28. But how footfalls and profitability evolve as alternative programming grows, and the company expands into tier-II and tier-III cities, remains to be seen.

The stock currently trades at 8 times EV/Ebitda, based on FY28 consensus Bloomberg estimates. An upward rerating is possible if expansion and diversification boost footfalls, while sustaining the margin trajectory.

Godrej Consumer's new CEO bets on core brands for growth

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MUMBAI

Godrej Consumer Products Ltd's (GCPL) new managing director and chief executive officer, Aasif Malbari, on Wednesday outlined a strategy to boost the company's volume and profit growth, three weeks after formally taking charge.

In a call with analysts and investors, Malbari presented a report card of the last five years, characterizing GCPL's growth as "good but not great", highlighting that the company's underlying volume and profit after tax grew at a single-digit compound annual growth rate since 2021, when Sudhir Sitapati was first appointed as CEO.

Now, Malbari is planning a number of changes, including a ₹200 crore investment in a new research and development facility, improvements in digital marketing, a cut in general trade inventory worth ₹125-150 crore over the next three quarters, and a sharpened focus on growing the company's core portfolio.

GCPL will bring down inventory days in the general trade to 10 days from the current 20 days, Malbari said, adding that new demand-forecasting tools have allowed the company to operate on a leaner, more capital-efficient model.



GCPL new CEO Aasif Malbari said the firm's core portfolio—soaps and Good Knight mosquito repellents—has been neglected.

"I'm making certain tweaks in the [company's] manifesto," he said. "The broad direction of the strategy remains the same. We are adding a few elements which we believe will allow us to... get to a better performance going forward."

Malbari said GCPL's core portfolio—soap brands Godrej No.1 and Cinthol, and Good Knight mosquito repellents—has been neglected. "Our core category revenue growth has been actually flat-ish with profits actually kind of being under pressure," he said.

"I think... because we had moved on to doing a lot more, we did have to prioritize some of the new entries, and hence our core portfolio did not get the full benefit of what we could do in terms of R&D and innovation on to them. The

core has to come to industry-level growth, if not beyond."

Besides, he said, the company has struggled to translate strategy into execution, which has meant it has missed growth opportunities in large, promising categories.

"Fragrances are a huge opportunity," he said. "This is one of the big categories when it comes to 2040. We like the two brands which we acquired. We like the category a lot. We're really very happy with the potential it offers. We definitely couldn't have; we didn't get the execution right when it came to acquiring Park Avenue and integrating it. Over the next few quarters, we will solve for that."

The vision marks a departure from Sitapati's earlier growth strategy for GCPL. Among the biggest changes is a shift away from relying on "speedboats" to drive the company's overall revenue growth.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Yotta eyes early 2027 IPO, seeks \$1.5 billion

Reuters
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Indian data centre operator Yotta Data Services plans to launch an IPO in the January-March quarter of 2027, chief executive officer (CEO) Sunil Gupta told Reuters, as it seeks to capitalize on booming demand for AI computing infrastructure.

The Hiranandani Group-backed firm is looking to file draft IPO papers in October and aims to raise up to \$1.5 billion to repay debt, buy graphics processing units and expand sovereign cloud infrastructure that keeps data within national borders, he said.

The move comes as demand for AI computing infrastructure surges and global tech giants, including Google and Amazon, expand their presence in India.

Yotta is currently raising pre-IPO capital and expects the IPO portion to be smaller than initially planned because much of its fundraising target has already been met, Gupta said, declining to disclose revenue raised so far.

He said in a LinkedIn post last month that Yotta had raised \$150 million in primary growth capital at a valuation of about ₹37,000 crore (\$3.9 billion).

Yotta says it is India's largest provider of Nvidia-powered AI computing infrastructure.

NBFCs seek clarity on revolving credit

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Non-banks have sought clarity from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on the definition of revolving credit and exemptions for certain micro, small, and medium enterprise (MSME)-focused products, including supply-chain finance and invoice discounting, after the central bank proposed barring them from issuing such facilities.

Some have pleaded with the regulator to allow revolving credit facilities, albeit with tighter underwriting and disclosures to address any concerns, or issue a new framework for such loan products.

"RBI's issue may not be with the product itself but probably a visibility concern," said Jatinder Handoo, chief executive of industry body Unified Fintech Forum (UFF). "We need to find a way to work closely with the regulator to resolve or address those concerns because it doesn't appear to be a quantum issue, but about a lack of visibility around what is happening when you disburse a credit line," he said.

"It's a transaction-based product, hence, controls and checks and balances could be put in place to address any concerns," Handoo said, suggesting more transparency through new technologies like blockchain and artificial intelligence, where all stock stakeholders, including at the merchant level, have visibility around what is happening in the system.

Other suggestions include



Some have pleaded with the RBI to allow revolving credit facilities, albeit with tighter underwriting and disclosures. MINT

adopting tools such as utilization pattern monitoring, mandatory re-underwriting on repeated drawdowns, reassessment of repayment capacity on persistent utilization, and supervisory testing of whether fresh drawings are servicing old obligations.

"Those (help) distinguish a healthy revolver from a cosmetic one. A blanket prohibition doesn't," said Vivek Bimbrab, former banker and consulting head-stakeholder relations, at think tank National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER).

The UFF, formerly known as the Digital Lenders' Association of India (DLAI), and the Finance Industry Development Council (FIDC), the apex representative body and self-regulatory organization for non-banking financial companies

(NBFCs), have submitted their suggestions to RBI.

The central bank had sought feedback on the 6 August draft circular by 28 August.

The draft raised concerns among non-banks about its impact on business, particularly certain credit facilities

extended to MSMEs and small businesses, as well as their access to capital.

In a 10 August note, Kotak Institutional Equities said that the norms will increase operational nuances, lower interest returns for lenders, and lead to higher operational expenses for borrowers, flagging that NBFCs such as Aditya Birla Finance, Bajaj Finance, and Tata Capital may take a hit.

NBFCs offer flexi/revolving credit facilities, mostly to MSME loan customers, including secured loans against prop-

erty, unsecured loans, supply-chain loans, and working capital loans, and, in some cases, personal and professional loans.

The FIDC, in its submission, said that many small and medium NBFCs, including captive NBFCs, deal exclusively in such products. "Consequent to such prohibition, the economic rationale for their continued existence shall be severely dented, leading to loss of investor/public funds and employment to personnel working in such NBFCs."

RBI's concerns, on the other hand, seem to stem from credit line-like products, wherein lenders typically sanction an overarching credit line to borrowers, who then have the option to withdraw only the amount they need. However, in certain cases where borrowers are under financial stress or unable to repay, they tend to withdraw more from the sanctioned line, or lenders extend more credit to avoid declaring the account as stressed or delinquent.

"That is evergreening wearing a product label. With household leverage climbing, it's a fair thing to worry about," said Bimbrab. "The regulator's concern is legitimate: A revolving facility can quietly mask deterioration," he said.

But NBFCs typically serve borrowers who don't meet banks' credit filters. "Take revolving credit away from NBFCs, and that customer does not migrate to a bank overdraft. He simply loses the product," Bimbrab said.

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Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed



Headcount at listed Adani firms falls on outsourcing

Group's workforce across nine listed firms fell 8.4% to 115,920 in FY26 for the first time

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The Adani Group's headcount across its listed companies fell for the first time last fiscal as one of India's largest private sector employers started outsourcing jobs to vendors. After including outsourced roles and employees in its unlisted entities, however, the conglomerate's total workforce strength increased by a fifth.

The number of people employed with the Adani Group's nine listed companies declined to 115,920 in FY26 from 126,499 in the previous year, as per disclosures made in their respective annual reports. The 8.4% drop came as the group committed record capital expenditure of ₹1.53 trillion during FY26 to fund expansion across its numerous businesses from ports to renewable energy.

An Adani Group spokesperson said the group's total workforce, including employees and workers across listed and unlisted entities, stood at 390,080 as of 31 July. The headcount had grown by 59,960 people since 31 March 2025, he said, over the past 16 months.

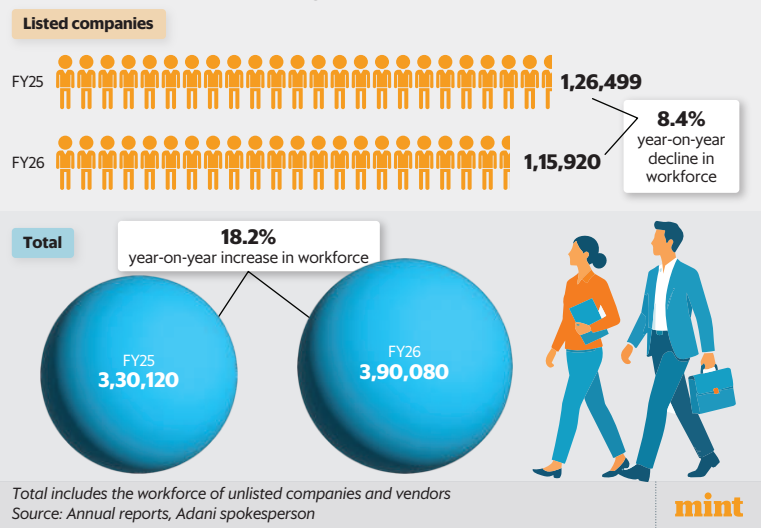
However, the workforce is increasingly being employed by third-party vendors and thus do not get tallied in the annual reports of the listed companies. *Mint* reported earlier, citing people familiar with the matter and the developments.

The Ahmedabad-based conglomerate is transferring roles such as manufacturing shopfloor workers and transport drivers to third-party vendors. While a large number of the group's on-site employees have been moved to the rolls of such vendors in recent months, *Mint* reported in June that many more are expected to go through a similar transition in the

Rolls and reality

The number of people directly employed by Adani's listed firms fell as jobs increasingly moved to vendors and unlisted entities.

Number of employees in the Adani group



months ahead.

"The figures cited by *Mint* cover only the group's nine listed companies and do not reflect the total workforce. On a comparable basis, workforce strength has continued to increase," the spokesperson said, without specifying the

of 31 March, about half of the 38,988 on the rolls a year ago. In percentage terms, the biggest drop was at Adani Green Energy Ltd, where the headcount dropped by over three-quarters to 976 from 4,107 a year prior.

The decision to outsource work to

the group's frantic pace of growth, *Mint* reported.

So, it will shed non-core functions to large vendors and focus on strategy and capital management instead. The conglomerate will oversee research and development and finance and retain intellectual property rights like manufacturing designs, but let vendors manage manufacturing, logistics and other labour-intensive operations.

Even among vendors, the group is pushing for larger, more established partners who can manage end-to-end operations rather than outsourcing each job to a smaller partners.

"Our endeavour is to work with a selected group of strong and reliable partners who can take responsibility for the entire task and complete it better, faster, and more effectively," Gautam Adani, the group's founder and chairperson, said in a groupwide address on 1 May on the occasion of Labour Day. "This is a change in mindset; this is a change in culture."

The 115,920 headcount at the end of FY26 includes permanent and non-permanent employees and workers directly on the rolls of the listed Adani companies. Indian reporting standards for listed firms distinguish between employees, which include personnel in managerial and administrative roles, and workers, who are non-managerial staff engaged in manual, operational, technical or clerical roles across different functions within the group.

The chief employees in the conglomerate are Adani Enterprises, its cash cows Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd and Adani Power Ltd, and its cement business under Ambuja Cements Ltd. The other listed companies in the group include Adani Green Energy, Adani Energy Solutions Ltd, Adani Total Gas Ltd, ACC Ltd, and NDTV Ltd.

Hexaware names Vivek Jetley as CEO after Srikrishna exit

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Hexaware Technologies Ltd on Wednesday ended chief executive officer (CEO) Ramakarthik-eyan Srikrishna's 12-year tenure, naming EXL executive Vivek Jetley as his successor in a move that hands the leadership of the IT services company to an outsider.

Jetley previously headed a \$1.4 billion business at EXL, overseeing insurance, health-care and life sciences segments. He had been with EXL for two decades, after joining the New York-headquartered business process outsourcing (BPO) firm in 2006.

Jetley was appointed CEO for a four-year term after Hexaware's 11-member board approved Srikrishna's resignation on Wednesday, choosing an external successor in an 18-minute meeting, according to a company statement.

"Vivek brings a proven ability to scale businesses, deepen enterprise relationships and build Data and AI-led growth platforms. As a major shareholder in Hexaware, Carlyle is excited to support Vivek as he steps into this role, and thanks Keech for his contributions to Hexaware over the past 12 years," said Sandra Horbach, Hexaware board member and chair of Americas Corporate Private Equity at Carlyle, in the statement. Pennsylvania-based private equity firm Carlyle owns 74.3% of Hexaware.

Srikrishna, 56, among the longest-serving CEOs in India, oversaw Hexaware's return to the stock exchanges in February last year. He will remain with the company as a senior advisor and will hand over the reins to Jetley on 28 October.

Jetley, who led a \$1.4 bn unit at EXL, will succeed Srikrishna, who will remain as a senior advisor at Hexaware



The company ended last year with \$1.54 billion in revenue, up 7.6% on a yearly basis.

Jetley becomes the firm's fourth CEO after Rusi Brij, P.R. Chandrasekar, and Srikrishna, who took charge in 2004, 2008, and 2014, respectively. Srikrishna's current term was set to end on 1 March 2028. His departure comes 14 months before the end of his tenure.

"Serving in this role has been one of the most fulfilling chapters of my professional life, and I am deeply grateful for the trust placed in me by the Board, our shareholders, and the broader Hexaware family. During my tenure, I have had the privilege of witnessing and contributing to a meaningful transformation of the company, both in terms of financial performance and the positive impact we have had on our associates, clients, and partners," Srikrishna said in his resignation letter.

Under Srikrishna, Hexaware became India's newest-listed tech services firm and joined the billion-dollar club

when it returned to the stock exchanges in February 2025. The company's stock settled 1.3% lower at ₹545.00 on the BSE on Wednesday.

The company, which follows a January-December fiscal calendar as against Indian IT's April-March, ended last year with \$1.54 billion in revenue, up 7.6% on a yearly basis. It reported the third-fastest growth amongst the 13 tech services firms getting more than a billion dollars in annual revenue. It lagged Coforge Ltd and Persistent Systems Ltd, which grew at 29.2% and 17.4%, respectively.

Its operating margin rose 80 basis points from a year earlier to 14.4%. Only Mphasis fared worse, with its margins steady at 15.3%. Under Srikrishna, growth was still a sore spot as the company grew at a compounded quarterly rate of 1.76% between March 2025 and July 2026. This was lower than peers Coforge, Mphasis, and Persistent Systems, which grew 7.62%, 1.82%, and 3.81% during this time, respectively. *Mint* has taken March 2025 as its starting point because the company listed in February that year.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Subhash Chandra opposes NCLT bench

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Zee Group founder Subhash Chandra on Wednesday opposed the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT)'s decision to constitute a five-member bench to hear his personal insolvency case afresh, questioning the legal basis for expanding the bench after three members gave differing views on his repayment plan.

In the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), Chandra's counsel argued that Section 419(5) of the Companies Act, which deals with differences of opinion among tribunal members, did not give the NCLT the power to constitute a five-member bench.

"The scope of Section 419(5) is very limited... It does not give power to the NCLT under the IBC or company law to form a five-member bench", Chandra's counsel argued.

Chandra's counsel also opposed the move to hear the entire case again. He argued that the earlier order approving the repayment plan could not be set aside. He also ques-



The case involves Zee founder Chandra's personal guarantees for ₹2,574 crore of loans linked to Essel and Zee Group firms.

tioned the five-judge bench, which had stayed the third judicial member (Nilesh Sharma)'s order approving the repayment plan.

NCLAT kept the creditor's challenge to Subhash Chandra's repayment plan pending. The appellate tribunal decided not to dispose of the appeal for now, leaving the challenge open in the meantime, as the NCLT is hearing the matter afresh after constituting a five-judge bench.

After hearing the argu-

Chandra's counsel argued that Section 419(5) doesn't empower the NCLT to constitute a five-member bench

ments, NCLAT decided to hear the matter on October 7.

On Tuesday, a newly formed five-member NCLT bench led by president Justice

Anupinder Singh Grewal clarified that the order of member Nilesh Sharma, delivered on 25 August, could not be given effect at this stage, because it did not constitute the majority view of the tribunal.

A day earlier, the appellate tribunal had agreed to hear an urgent plea by several creditors seeking to challenge the

NCLT Delhi bench's approval of the repayment plan proposed by Zee Group founder.

Minutes after the NCLT special bench proceedings ended, solicitor general Tushar Mehta appeared before NCLAT on behalf of creditors including LIC Housing Finance, HDFC Bank and Union Bank of India.

Mehta asked the NCLAT to consider whether its intervention was needed at this point, now that the NCLT had stayed the earlier order.

The case concerns Chandra's liability as a personal guarantor for loans taken by companies linked to the Essel Group and the Zee Group.

In February, a two-member bench of the NCLT differed on whether his repayment plan would be binding on dissenting creditors. Sharma, who was brought in as the third member, approved the plan and held that it would be binding on dissenting creditors.

Government officials told *Mint* earlier that about ₹2,574 crore of claims were related to loans for which Chandra had given personal guarantees when they were taken.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Govt can't revive old dues after insolvency plan, says Delhi HC

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The Delhi High Court (HC) on Wednesday said government authorities cannot remain outside a firm's insolvency process and later seek recovery of old dues after a resolution plan is approved.

The ruling related to the claims by customs department for digital and network video recorders imported by Jaiprakash Associates in September 2023, before the company entered insolvency on 3 June 2024. The department, which did not file its claim during the insolvency process, alleged on 2 June 2026 that the company had paid basic customs duty at 10% instead of 20% and sought ₹589,000 in additional customs duty, along with interest and penalty.

Jaiprakash Associates challenged the order in high court. The court said creditors, including government agencies such as tax authorities, must raise their claims during the insolvency process. They cannot wait for their dues to be



The case relates to Jaiprakash Associates' imports.

decided and then seek payment after the process is over.

"The object of IBC would be defeated if a creditor, including a statutory authority, were permitted to stand outside the CIRP (Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process), await adjudication of a pre-CIRP liability and then seek enforcement against the resolved Corporate Debtor," the court said.

A public notice had invited creditors to submit claims, with 17 June 2024 as the last date. But, Customs did not file its claim during the insolvency process. "The responsibility of

identifying and filing its claim lies upon the creditor," it said, adding that the company was not required to separately inform every government department about the insolvency. It was the creditor's responsibility to file its claim.

Creditors also cleared Adani Enterprises' resolution plan worth over ₹15,000 crore on 31 October 2025. The National Company Law Tribunal approved it on 17 March. The plan said old claims that had not been filed, accepted, or verified will be treated as nil.

The HC said allowing customs' claim will defeat the purpose of the insolvency law and leave new owners facing unexpected old dues. The idea is to give successful buyer a "clean slate" so that it knows the liabilities it is taking on, it added.

The court quashed the Customs order confirming the duty, interest and penalty. It did not decide whether Jaiprakash Associates was actually entitled to the lower 10% customs duty rate, as that issue was no longer necessary.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

ONGC reviews assets in Venezuela after US nod

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A team from the international investment arm of Oil & Natural Gas Corp. Ltd (ONGC) has arrived in Venezuela to review assets in the country, according to people familiar with the matter, weeks after the company received a green light from the US.

During a seven-day stay that began on Tuesday, a team of nearly a dozen officials from state-run ONGC Videsh Ltd (OVL) plans to see oil fields and meet Venezuelan energy officials, the people said. It will be the first such visit in years, they added.

OVL received the US government's approval in July, a step that removes sanctions-related restrictions and allows the company to resume oil and gas operations in Venezuela, where it owns stakes in San Cristobal and Carabobo-1 project.

OVL is in discussions to sign a framework agreement with Venezuela and is keen to become operator of both the projects, the company's managing director, Rajarshi Gupta, told reporters in New Delhi earlier this week: "We do believe both the assets have substantial chance and possibility of multiplying production."

The tour comes as US energy secretary Chris Wright arrives in Venezuela to announce a series of deals aimed at ramping up the nation's oil fields, in part to ease pressure on global crude prices, driven higher by disruption in the Persian Gulf.

OVL holds a 40% stake in Venezuela's San Cristobal field and 11% in the Carabobo-1 block. State-run Indian Oil Corp. Ltd and India Ltd each hold 3.5% in Carabobo-1.

Ramayana, upcoming mythological films could face backlash, legal risk

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With the Shri Ramlila Mahasangh demanding a preview of Nitesh Tiwari's big-budget mythological epic *Ramayana*, experts said the upcoming slate of mythological films could be at risk.

While titles such as *Mahakali*, *Mahavata* and *Adhira* are likely to draw attention given their links to Indian traditions and sentiments, controversies over casting, costumes, chronology, violence and portrayals of women and communities could arise. The possible consequences include a social-

media backlash and legal notices impacting the marketing, distribution, release schedules and costs of high-profile films that could fall prey to demands of religious outfits and fringe groups even though they have no legal right to stop them.

According to media reports, Shri Ramlila Mahasangh issued a warning to the *Ramayana* makers, requesting a special screening before the expected release in November to avoid inaccurate depictions similar to those in the 2023 film *Adipurush*.

In a letter addressed to director Tiwari and the production house, Arjun Kumar Singh, president of the Shri Ramlila Mahasangh, recalled



The risk is substantial because mythological narratives are linked to faith, worship and differing textual interpretations.

that the earlier film triggered objections from members of the Sanatan community and those associated with traditional Ramlila performances.

He said the Sangh received information that *Ramayana* may contain scenes that could hurt the sentiments of Hindus living in India and abroad.

The Mahasangh coordinates hundreds of Ramlila committees that stage the epic in Delhi-NCR every year. The leader of the organization told *Mint* that the organization is concerned after watching the *Ramayana* trailer.

"Some costumes shown in the film weren't in use in that period. We've asked for the film to be shown to us before release so we can point out if there are inaccuracies and they can be corrected. That way, the film will run and no feelings will be hurt."

Singh said gods and goddesses can't be depicted inaccurately. The organization is waiting for the *Ramayana* makers to get back, and they may stage protests if there is no response.

"The sensitivity is considerably greater because filmmakers are dealing with characters and narratives which a large section of the audience does not regard merely as mythology or literature, but as part of a living religious and cultural tradition," said Ankit Sahni, partner

EPIC MINEFIELD

FILM MAKERS face greater sensitivity when adapting stories seen as living religious traditions

PROTESTS and legal challenges could affect marketing, distribution and release schedules

IPO shares debut with average 28% gain in August

FROM PAGE 1

launched after such a pause tend to be priced conservatively and leave more on the table to attract investors, which then results in healthy listing-day gains," Haldea said.

The return of so-called listing pops, when a stock jumps on its first day of trading, indicates that companies valuing themselves conservatively in a volatile market, leaving enough for the investors who crowd these counters on listing.

The August upswing extended across sectors including industrial equipment manufacturing, enterprise software, logistics platforms and consumer goods. Listing-day gains were observed across the board, irrespective of underlying profitability, corporate cash flows or management quality.

Other market participants attributed the surge to investor behaviour, driven by the recent price momentum across primary market offerings and a fear of missing out on a large pay day.

"There is an element of retail Fomo (fear of missing out) returning to the primary market," said Deven Choksey, founder and managing director at DRChoksey FinServ.

"When individual investors see back-to-back listings posting strong single-day returns, subscription momentum feeds on itself. Most investors participating through IPO subscription try fulfilling their leftover appetite on the listing day. That sudden influx of retail market orders at the exchange



Listing pops appear to have made a comeback. BLOOMBERG

open creates a demand imbalance, pushing listing premiums well past what business fundamentals alone would justify."

From January to July-end, retail investors of mainboard IPOs bid for an average of just under 12 times the number of shares on offer. In August alone, though, the average retail subscription to IPOs jumped to almost 33 times.

From Jan to Jul, retail investors of mainboard IPOs bid for an average of just under 12 times the number of shares on offer

Recently, concerns have emerged over the influence of unofficial pre-listing transactions on public subscription patterns. Grey market premiums operate outside official exchange trading mechanisms, yet their reported figures directly shape subscription decisions by retail investors and high-net-worth bidding syndicates.

As of 2 September, indications from grey market trading suggest listing premiums may extend into upcoming mainboard offerings.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Hotel firms tap unexplored India, from Kabini to Salasar

ITC Hotels, IHCL, others eye remote markets as development peaks in the bigger cities

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As the country's domestic tourism grows, riding India's buoyant leisure travel trend, listed hospitality companies are rapidly signing up hotels in obscure micro-markets from Barapani to Maniyagarh Hills and Omkareshwar.

Hotel companies are fanning out, looking aggressively for contracts to increase not only their income from management fee but also to widen their presence across tier-3 and -4 markets as development peaks in the bigger cities. Recent signings include ITC Hotels' Storri at Amchong Tea Estate on the outskirts of Guwahati and a Welcomhotel in Salasar, Rajasthan. ITC has also signed a Welcomhotel each in Rajgir in Bihar and Karai in Gujarat.

"We have signed 87 hotels in the past three years, including in Karai, Balarum Palace resort in Palampur and opened 43 hotels in the last three years. We also opened one in Akashganga in Durgapur district of Rajasthan and one in Naina Tikkar in Himachal Pradesh," said Anil Chadha, managing director of ITC Hotels.

Tajparent The Indian Hotels Co Ltd (IHCL), on the other hand, has added properties in Jawai, Bharatpur, in Rajasthan, Sindhurg in Maharashtra and signed one in Barapani, Meghalaya.

Lemon Tree announced hotels in Omkareshwar and Chitrakoot in Madhya Pradesh in January, Khurpatal in Uttarakhand, Barog in Himachal and Gorakhpur in Uttar Pradesh.

Scale is becoming less about room count alone and more about the breadth of brands and distribution that a company can offer owners and guests. Oberoi Hotels parent EIH has been tak-



Domestic travel market is increasingly underpinning the hotel industry, with local visitor spending pegged at \$203 billion in 2025, or 86% of total tourism spending. MINT

ing its brands to destination-led markets, with recent and planned properties including Makaibari Tea Estate in West Bengal, Kabini and Hampi in Karnataka, and Rajgarh Palace atop the Maniyagarh Hills in Madhya Pradesh. The expansion is not simply about

Siwan in Bihar in June, followed by boutique resort Tree of Life Himalaya in Hartola, Uttarakhand, and another one in Chettinad, Tamil Nadu.

Dimitris Manikis, president, EMEA, at Wyndham Hotels & Resorts, the world's largest hotel franchising com-

RURAL HOSPITALITY

HOTEL firms are looking for pockets of demand that can support branded accommodation

FIRMS are fanning out, looking for contracts to raise their income from management fee

RECENT signings include ITC Hotels' Storri at Amchong Tea Estate in Guwahati

DEMAND in smaller locations can also be generated locally in the form of family occasions, weddings

moving into smaller cities, said consultants. Hotel companies are looking for pockets of demand that can support branded accommodation, with destinations increasingly built around a specific travel proposition rather than simply the size of the city.

IHCL opened a 30-room Ginger in

pany and operator of brands including Ramada, Days Inn and Microtel, said: "India is changing so rapidly that a tier-3 city can become a tier-2 market within months as new airports and highways come in. Look at the infrastructure pipeline: 27 airports are being developed in India and another 50 are

in the pipeline, compared with virtually none in Europe."

Domestic travel market is increasingly underpinning the hotel industry, with the World Travel & Tourism Council pegging local visitor spending at \$203 billion in 2025, or 86% of total travel and tourism spending.

Consultancy HVS Anarock, in its January 2026 review of 2025, said domestic tourism was the sector's strongest pillar, with short breaks, drive-to leisure travel, pilgrimages, weddings helping tier-2 and -3 cities gain ground on the travel map.

For hotel management companies, this offers a way to expand without having to own the underlying real estate, said Rattan Keswani, deputy managing director of Lemon Tree Hotels. "Portfolio breadth is now becoming as important as the hotel or room count. It is really about strengthening and carpet-bombing locations. Once one brand enters a market, others follow."

Royal Orchid is exploring emerging micro-locations such as Kevadia near the Statue of Unity in Gujarat. French hospitality major Accor is taking Novotel to Sambalpur, Odisha, with a 120-room property signed to open in 2031, expanding its footprint to fast-growing regional markets.

"Larger hotel companies are not looking to leave any empty spaces in their hotel portfolios," said Prashant Biyani, vice president and hospitality analyst at Elara Capital. "IHCL brought back Gateway and is expanding Ginger. They are expanding their presence where they are not right now. For hotel companies, it is about portfolio maximization, everywhere is the focus."

Other than Leela Palaces, Hotels and Resorts, which is focused on luxury, the others are expanding across categories.

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Work on the VF 6, along with the VF 3 and VF 7 halted. REUTERS

VinFast suspends work on making 3 EVs in India

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VinFast has suspended plans to manufacture three electric vehicles (EVs) in India and ordered suppliers to halt work on the projects while it reassesses costs, according to two sources and a company memo reviewed by Reuters - a year after the Vietnamese automaker entered the market.

The manufacturer has asked suppliers to "hold all activities" on three programmes, including a two-door SUV called VF 3, expected to be its most competitive model in the market, and VF 6 and VF 7 SUVs, which it imports as kits from Vietnam and assembles in the country.

The suspension marks another setback for loss-making VinFast, which has turned to India for growth after facing difficulties gaining market share in the US and Europe.

The suspension of plans to locally manufacture the three vehicles in India has not been previously reported.

VinFast opened its first factory outside Vietnam in southern India last year and pledged to invest \$2 billion, as it sought to build a regional manufacturing base serving South Asia, the Middle East and Africa.

After publication of this story, VinFast told Reuters the change in production strategy relates to future models and it will continue to import and assemble the VF 6 and VF 7 currently being sold in India. VinFast also said it plans to develop India-specific models, rather than just bringing in existing global models—a move that it says will allow it to accelerate local sourcing.

While VinFast has publicly stated increasing local sourcing, plans to manufacture the VF 3, VF 6 and VF 7 in India have not previously been disclosed and were described to Reuters by people in the know.

"India is an important market in VinFast's long-term business and manufacturing strategy," a company representative told Reuters in a statement, adding that based on market research and consumer feedback it is making "appropriate adjustments" to its products to "better meet the needs of Indian customers".

In a July memo to suppliers, the automaker said it decided to "temporarily" put on hold all development work related to the three EVs.

Audit firms tap AI sleuths, data gurus

FROM PAGE 1

3,000-5,000 each. According to senior auditors in the firms mentioned above, more than 95% of the teams comprised CAs just about a decade ago.

The teams now include data scientists and analytics professionals who analyze large datasets and flag anomalies and risks; cybersecurity specialists who evaluate cyber controls and organizational resilience; and IT auditors and enterprise resource planning (ERP) experts, who assess automated controls and broad tech risks.

These more well-rounded teams are eyeing mandates of 600 companies, who have changed or will go in for an auditor change between FY26 to FY29 as per the Companies Act regulations, setting in motion a once-in-a-decade churn that will transform India's audit market.

Deloitte points out that auditors need to prepare for developments such as implementation of Ind AS 118 disclosure standards, ESG sustainability reporting requirements, enhanced disclosure expectations and industry-specific regulatory norms. Controls around unpublished price



Auditors must now be aware of the impact of AI. ISTOCKPHOTO

sensitive information, along with labour code compliance needs also require attention.

Importantly, the auditors must now be aware of the impact of AI, which can throw up plausible but inaccurate company details. "There's an explosion of AI and automation in finance itself, with teams using MS Copilot in Excel, ChatGPT for reconciliations and robotic process automation bots for journal postings and bank reconciliations. We need to audit but identify as if it were a user," said Vishal Divadkar, managing partner and head of audit and assurance MSKA & Associates, member of BDO International.

The managing partner noted that the composition of audit teams has "completely changed in the past decade or so, and it isn't just the conventional CA partner, senior, manager or only financial audit anymore". The new teams are "multidisciplinary" to include technology experts, forensic/fraud specialists for whistleblower/super abuse cases, domain experts to address the remote working/voluminous data/regulatory reporting requirements.

Experts are recruited from their respective industries, and in some cases even trained internally for new specializations. A senior auditor in one of

the five firms mentioned above said he had to learn with the AI team to make simulations to convince clients. Diverse teams lead to accepting more complex and large audits that in turn could help them command higher fees.

Audit firms need to put their most diverse and capable auditing foot forward as India Inc is getting choosy about who can scrutinize them.

Over the past few years, large companies across sectors have faced significant disruption and transformation, driven by geopolitical developments, geographic expansion, increasingly complex regulatory requirements and, most notably, the rise of big data and AI," said Arvind Sethi, national leader, S.R. Batliboi & Co. (audit network firm for EY Global). "As a result, they are increasingly assessing auditors' capabilities to keep pace with technological advancements, using AI effectively in audits and providing confidence to stakeholders."

"In a digital business, the

audit trail begins before the first number reaches the ledger. Trust in the numbers now depends on trust in the systems, access rights and data that create them," said Abhishek Rara, partner at Price Waterhouse LLP. "The auditor must understand not only the financial transaction, but also the technology, data flows and control environment behind it. That calls for an integrated approach across financial audit, IT, data, cybersecurity and other specialist teams".

Apart from these new-era factors, the selection process, of course, involves deeper reviews on audit quality. "Audit quality indicators are receiving greater focus, and boards are increasingly taking into account outcomes of regulatory inspections, including observations from bodies such as National Financial Reporting Authority, as part of their evaluation process," said Sudhir Soni, head of audit at BSR & Co LLP.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

More than 95% of the teams comprised chartered accountants just about a decade ago

SoftBank to offload 1.5% stake in Meesho

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Masayoshi Son's SoftBank Group Corp. is offering to sell 70 million shares in Indian e-commerce platform Meesho Ltd through a block deal on Thursday, according to a term sheet reviewed by Mint.

The seller, SoftBank-affiliated SVF II Meerkat (DE) LLC, is offering a 1.5% stake in the Vidit Aatrey-led company, with the floor price for the shares being set at ₹205 rupees per share, representing a 3.1% discount to Meesho's closing price of ₹211.60 on 2 September on the National Stock Exchange.

At the floor price, the total deal is worth about ₹1,435 crore (around \$151 million).

BofA Securities India Ltd and J.P. Morgan India Pvt. Ltd are serving as placement agents for the transaction. The term sheet specifies a 60-day lock-up period for the seller.

SoftBank's stake sale in the scrip will follow Y Combinator-linked entities selling 48.5



Meesho's lock-in for pre-IPO shares ended on 9 June. AFP

million Meesho shares worth ₹970 crore through block deals on 24 August, and American major Fidelity Investments Co. offloading a 1.3% stake worth ₹988 crore in the new-age tech stock on 11 June. The stock's lock-in for pre-IPO shares expired on 9 June.

The Japanese investment major has also sold large blocks in Lenskart Solutions Ltd earlier this year. Its arm sold Lenskart shares worth ₹2,888 crore in August and ₹2,873 crore in June.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Banks' CD rates plunge as FCNR flows cross \$127 billion

FROM PAGE 1

external commercial borrowings (ECBs) \$3.9 billion.

As liquidity swelled, touching ₹7.8 trillion on 1 September from ₹1.85 trillion on 5 June, rates cooled in the CD market. Central Bank of India on Tuesday raised ₹1,000 crore by issuing CDs maturing on 2 December at 6.38%, compared to ₹500 crore it raised at 6.60% on 27 August for a similar maturity. On 6 March, the bank had raised ₹250 crore through three-month CDs at 7.15%. Crest Finserv data showed.

"CD rates have fallen because banks are flush with FCNR(B) inflows and overall

system liquidity has risen substantially, reducing their need to raise funds through CDs. Lower issuance is also putting downward pressure on CD rates," said Gopal Tripathi, treasury head at Jana Small Finance Bank.

The RBI introduced the swap window allowing banks to offer interest rates as high as 7.10% on 3- to 5-year foreign currency deposits for NRIs by covering the banks' currency exchange costs. The scheme also allowed NRIs to make leveraged deposits, increasing its allure. The scheme drew on an earlier effort in 2013, when Indian banks successfully raised \$26 billion in foreign inflows.

The surplus funds have sharply reduced banks' dependence on CDs. In August, banks raised ₹68,130 crore through CDs, lower than the ₹95,945 crore raised in July, according to data from Primedatabase.com. The RBI's August bulletin noted the trend, stating CD rates softened in the second half of July and August as improved liquidity and FCNR(B) inflows reduced banks' dependence on CDs.

CDs are short-term debt instruments that banks issue to raise funds, typically from institutional investors. Banks had increased their reliance on CDs as retail deposit growth struggled to keep pace with



With the surge in FCNR(B) inflows, banks are now flush with funds and their need to raise money through CDs has fallen sharply. AFP

credit demand, using the wholesale funding route to bridge the gap and support loan growth. However, with the surge in FCNR(B) inflows,

banks are now flush with funds and their need to raise money through CDs has fallen sharply, reducing CD issuance and pushing rates lower.

Total liquidity infusion through the RBI's 5 June measures is estimated at ₹3.6 trillion over 5 June to 14

August and liquidity could peak at ₹9.9 trillion in September before gradually declining to ₹5.4 trillion by March 2027 as currency leakage rises and the balance of payments moves closer to neutral, according to a 27 August report by IDFC First Bank.

Since the RBI incentivized the FCNR(B) scheme, it has been using variable rate reverse

repo (VRRRs) auctions to suck out excess liquidity from the system. However, IDFC First Bank believes that the RBI may

need to use stronger measures as the surplus rises further in September. Yet, the sharp fall in CD rates has not translated into a broad-based easing across the fixed-income market as investors remain cautious about deploying money into government securities and corporate bonds.

"While CD rates coming down is an advantage, this eas-

ing is not percolating to the other parts of the yield curve in the fixed-income market because of other concerns and the way oil is behaving," a senior treasury official at a private bank said.

Global bond yields have risen as markets price in tighter monetary policy from central banks world over. Recent RBI minutes also showed that Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) members are recalibrating a rate hike based on the inflation-growth outlook. Yield on the 10-year benchmark government bond has risen to 6.98% from 6.82% since 20 August, and is likely to weigh on short-term markets as well.



TVS Motor makes global picks for growth, leadership

Automaker is aiming for a larger global share, working to revive iconic British brand Norton

Ayaan Kartik
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BENGALURU

TVS Motor Co. Ltd is increasingly looking beyond India not just for growth, but also for the people shaping it. As the two-wheeler firm steps up overseas push and works to revive iconic British motorcycle brand Norton, several key strategic roles are now being led from Singapore, Dubai and the UK, alongside a growing roster of executives with global experience.

This shift will get more pronounced in January, when Dubai-based Peyman Kargar takes over as the CEO.

Chairman and managing director Sudarshan Venu and president group strategy Sharad Mohan Mishra are currently based out of Singapore, while Kargar, currently the president of international business, is based out of Dubai, according to company announcements, their professional LinkedIn profiles and two persons in the know.

Earlier this year, the firm appointed former Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) executive director Nick Rogers as president and chief technology officer, based out of Bengaluru and Oxford in the UK.

JLR chief creative officer Gerry McGovern was also hired as chief creative advisor for the firm's Norton brand in 2025, which ran into controversy earlier this year. McGovern finally left JLR in March. The controversy was over the conflict of interest in the hiring. In an objection filed with Maharashtra Charity Commissioner in April, former Tata Trusts member Mehli Mistry had alleged a conflict of interest in TVS Motor chairman emeritus Venu Srinivasan, another trustee who also serves as a Tata Sons Ltd board member, hiring McGovern to work for his company.

The top brass hiring approach of TVS coincides with its efforts to revive



Dubai-based Peyman Kargar takes over as CEO in January.

UK's Norton Motorcycles and ramp up exports after the company overtook Yamaha to become world's third largest two-wheeler maker, showed data compiled by Autocar Professional.

"The roles responsible for execution

TWO-WHEELER makers are increasingly seeing a shakeup in leadership strategy

TVS's approach of looking outwards picked up after Sudarshan Venu became chairman

THE firm earlier this year named JLR's Nick Rogers as its president and chief technology officer

LAST year, TVS hired Gerry McGovern from JLR as chief creative advisor for the Norton brand

of strategy are based out of India but the strategic roles are increasingly based in Singapore," one of the persons mentioned above said.

Gaurav Gupta, president of the India two-wheeler business, Aniruddha Hal-
dar, head of electric vehicle (EV) and

ing with Japan's Nissan and French firm Renault, joining TVS as president for international business in May 2025.

Notably, Kargar has never worked with an India-based automaker before. Since the announcement on the new CEO on Friday, TVS shares have fallen by

5% as against a 1.9% dip in the Nifty Auto.

Responding to *Mint's* queries, a company spokesperson said TVS's strategy reflects its strategic priorities across India and the global markets. "Our global talent strategy builds on the strong foundation of talent, capabilities and leadership across the business, bringing together an exceptional mix of experience and expertise from markets around the world to further strengthen the organization and delight our customers."

"This combination of deep market understanding, engineering excellence and global experience has supported strong business performance in India and internationally, strengthened our leadership in electric mobility and contributed to the continued expansion of our global business," he added.

The spokesperson said Kargar brings extensive global automotive experience, has already played an important role in the growth of international business, and will be based in Bengaluru. Incumbent CEO Radhakrishnan is also based in Bengaluru.

The company's approach of looking outwards for new leaders gathered steam after Venu, the son of chair emeritus Venu Srinivasan, took over as chairman in August 2025.

Two-wheeler makers are increasingly seeing a shakeup in leadership strategy, with Hero MotoCorp Ltd also picking top executives with experience from outside the industry as it prepares to shift focus on premium vehicles, exports and EVs.

According to fiscal year 2026 (FY26) data from the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers, TVS Motor's two-wheeler sales in the domestic market grew 20% to 4.2 million units while exports saw a 27% rise to 1.4 million units.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

AB InBev turns to state policy shifts for its next India bets

Varuni Khosla
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NEW DELHI



Stable policy creates a better investment climate, said Kartikeya Sharma, president, AB InBev India and Southeast Asia.

Budweiser-maker Anheuser-Busch InBev (AB InBev India) is stepping up investments in the country, putting more money behind states where policy changes are making the economics of selling beer more attractive. The world's largest brewer has invested an average of over \$25 million a year in capacity expansion in India, including faster canning lines and brewery upgrades, as it bets on markets offering greater flexibility on pricing and more affordable beer.

The brewer has invested about \$10 million in localizing production of Corona and Hoegaarden, while its latest investment in Rajasthan is expected to be about \$20 million, Kartikeya Sharma, president, AB InBev India and Southeast Asia, told *Mint*. Overall, the company says it has invested \$1.5 billion in India since AB InBev acquired SABMiller in 2016.

But where the next round of capital goes will increasingly depend on state policy. Sharma pointed to Maharashtra and Karnataka as examples of how the changes in taxation, retail and pricing can improve the economics of beer and encourage brewers to invest ahead of demand. "The investment climate plays out organically when a state's policy towards beer consumption is stable and predictable."

The Belgium-headquartered company, last month, restarted its brewery in Rajasthan, which it had shut seven years ago after struggling with "unfavourable taxation, poor

bottle returns (for recycling) and other policy issues".

The company has now made fresh investments in Rajasthan, including on additional production capacity to produce its popular Budweiser beer. India is the third biggest market for Budweiser, competing with China and the US.

AB InBev now sees Rajasthan as a growth market after three consecutive years of what it considers more favourable beer policies. On the other hand, markets such as Uttar Pradesh and Odisha have been unfavourable for beer sales with the states actively discouraging companies from taking price increases on the beverage.

UP remains one of AB InBev's five top beer markets by volume, but it said the company has not got a price increase there for three years, even as costs have risen. "If states don't allow companies to take price increases, how do we make an investment even when we want to?" Sharma added.

AB InBev estimates that India consumes about 36.7 million hectolitres of beer a year (about 446 million cases

of 12 bottles per case with 650 ml per bottle), and puts its own share at about 20%. Market leader, Kingfisher-maker, United Breweries Ltd (UBL) commands about 50% share.

Like its rival, the company has also been gaining from the shift towards premium and super-premium beer, which now accounts for more than a fifth of the overall market, according to its estimates.

It holds about 60% of the premium and super-premium segments (brands such as Corona, Stella Artois, Budweiser, and others) and expects this part of its portfolio to account for about a quarter of its India business over the coming three-to-four years.

Corona and Hoegaarden continue to have room for expansion, with their distribution still significantly smaller than Budweiser's, Sharma said, adding that it could benefit from 330 ml cans.

In May this year, Karnataka made changes to its alcohol taxation structure, with the tax depending on the amount of alcohol in it, rather than per bottle. The company has since seen an increase in sales of its mild beer contribution from about 9-10% to nearly 20% in three months, Sharma said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

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NOTICE OF 39TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND E-VOTING INFORMATION

NOTICE is hereby given that 39th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of Bhartiya International Limited ("the Company") will be held on **Monday, September 28, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. (IST)** through Video Conferencing ("VC") Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM"), to transact the business, as set out in the Notice convening 39th AGM of the Company.

In compliance with Section 96 of the Companies Act, 2013, SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") read with various circulars issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs including the latest General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025, the AGM of the Company will be held through VC/OAVM.

Further, in accordance with the aforesaid Circulars, the Notice convening the 39th AGM and Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 have already been electronically sent to all the shareholders whose email addresses are registered with the Company and/or Depository Participant(s) ("DPs") and a letter providing web-link of Annual Report is also dispatched to the shareholders whose email addresses are not registered/available to Company/RTA.

Instructions for remote e-voting and e-voting during the AGM

- Pursuant to Section 108 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Act read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, as amended from time to time and Regulation 44 of the Listing Regulations and Secretarial Standards on General Meeting (SS-2) issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India, the Company is pleased to provide facility to its members, to cast their vote on all the Resolutions set forth in the Notice convening the AGM using electronic voting system ("remote e-Voting"), provided by **National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL")**. The detailed procedure/instructions in this respect have been provided in notes to the Notice of AGM.
- The members of the Company, holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialised form, as on the Cut-off date i.e., **Monday, September 21, 2026**, may cast their vote electronically. The remote e-voting period commences on **Friday, September 25, 2026 (09:00 A.M. IST)** and ends on **Sunday, September 27, 2026 (05:00 P.M. IST)**. The e-Voting module shall be disabled by NSDL for voting after 05:00 P.M. (IST) on Sunday, September 27, 2026. Those who are not Members on the record date/cut-off date should accordingly treat the AGM Notice for information purposes only. Once the vote on a resolution is cast by the member, he/she shall not be allowed to change it subsequently. The voting rights of Members shall be in proportion to the shares held by them in the total paid-up Equity Share Capital of the Company as on the record date/cut-off date. Members who have already cast their votes through remote e-Voting prior to the AGM may also attend the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their votes again. Members attending the AGM who have not cast their votes through remote e-Voting shall be able to exercise their voting rights during the AGM.
- Any person, who acquires shares and become member of the Company after dispatch of the notice and holding shares on the **Cut-off date i.e., Monday, September 21, 2026** may obtain the login ID by referring the AGM notice. However, if you are already registered with NSDL for e-voting then you can use your existing user ID and password to cast your vote.
- The Board of Directors of the Company have appointed Mr. Ravi Sharma, Partner RSM & Co., Practising Company Secretary as the Scrutinizer to scrutinize the remote e-voting process & e-voting during AGM in a fair and transparent manner.
- In case of any queries pertaining to the voting or technical issue of login before/during the AGM, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Shareholders and e-voting user manual for Shareholders available at the download section of [www.evoting.nsdl.com](#) or call on: 022-4886 7000 or send a request at [evoting@nsdl.com](#). Alternatively, Members may also write to the Company Secretary of the Company at the email ID: [shares@bhartiya.com](#).

The Notice of the 39th AGM and Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 along with further details are made available on Company's website at [www.bhartiya.com](#), on website of Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited at [www.bseindia.com](#) and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at [www.nseindia.com](#) and on the website of NSDL at [www.evoting.nsdl.com](#).

Shareholders who hold shares in dematerialised form and wish to update their KYC details/email address are requested to contact their respective Depository Participants. Shareholders holding shares in physical form can send duly filled and signed request letter in Form ISR-1.

For Bhartiya International Limited
Sd/-
Yogesh Kumar Gautam
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer
Membership No. 31119

Date: 3rd September, 2026
Place: Gurugram, Haryana



G-20 squabbling overshadows summit as global bond markets strain

The finance ministers' gathering comes to a close amid a global bond-market selloff, spats over tariffs, public insults and fighting over a group photo

Matt Grossman, Brian Schwartz,
Paul Vieira & Kim Mackrael

ASHEVILLE, NORTH CAROLINA

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent arrived here to host global economic officials in the Blue Ridge Mountains, fresh off the breakdown of trade talks with Canada, currency and bond-market interventions, and President Trump's renewed economic threats against Iran.

Two days later, the G-20 finance ministers' gathering comes to a close amid a global bond-market selloff, spats over tariffs, public insults and fighting over a group photo.

In a press conference at the summit's conclusion Tuesday night, Bessent said that meetings were productive, tackling trade imbalances, artificial intelligence and sovereign debt.

But the disconnect between the sideline bickering—a renamed Great Lake, a photo with a Russian minister—and the growing stress in global markets raised fears among many investors that leaders aren't confronting challenges that could quickly spiral out of control. As their meeting concluded on Tuesday, the benchmark 10-year Treasury yield rose to 4.795%, the highest since Trump began his second term.

Global economic leaders are now presiding over rising anxiety in financial markets at a particularly lousy moment. The Americans, carrying a staggering \$40 trillion in government debt, used this week's meeting to make the case that economic growth can outrun that debt.

"The world is awash in debt," Bessent told reporters Monday at the gathering. "The only way for us to get out of this is to grow our way out of it."

After the summit, Bessent said, "With America once again leading this forum, the days of settling for subpar growth are over. The discussions we've had here this week leave me confident that many of our partners are now prepared to join us."

The bond market, however, is rebelling against that premise—a selloff is sending yields higher and



Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, center, at the G-20 summit in Asheville, North Carolina.

AFP

raising governments' borrowing costs.

Bessent released a statement that he said reflected the general position of every country present except for China, which he said was unlikely to agree to a pointed statement about trade imbalances. The Wall Street Journal didn't independently confirm that all countries at the summit agreed with the statement.

"In particular, countries with excessive and persistent external surpluses should remove distortions that constrain domestic consumption and that result in an over-reliance on exports for growth," the Treasury statement said.

Without China, the group was unable to issue an official consensus statement.

It was a summit of squabbling from the start. The proceedings had barely begun when Bessent mocked Canada's military, dismissing it with a reference to a decommissioned amusement-park ride. Canadians seethed at Trump's move to rename Lake Ontario and redoubled their efforts to build

closer trade ties with other countries. Other delegates said the spat between close allies was an unnecessary distraction.

"I think that in this world where tensions are numerous, it's probably no time to add tensions, especially between two historical partners," French Finance Minister Roland Lescure said.

Meanwhile, Europeans were furious that Russian Finance Minister Anton Siluanov was invited.

(Russia hadn't been invited since it invaded Ukraine in

2022.) Bessent's threats to impose sanctions on Iran's trading partners hovered over his meeting with China's central bank governor Sunday. Bessent later told former Trump adviser Larry Kudlow at a G-20 event that the longtime U.S. adversary is on their side when it comes to certain aspects of the Iran conflict. China is a top trading partner with the Iranian regime.

"The Chinese agree Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon. The Chinese agree that there should be

freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz. We have had private discussions with them in terms of achieving those goals," Bessent told Kudlow just two days after meeting with the senior Chinese official.

The summit convened finance ministers and central bankers from the "Group of 20" rich and developing countries. The G-20 intends these events to be a substantive appetizer for the G-20 leaders summit, which this year Trump will host at his Doral, Fla., resort in December.

Tradition held to bring together the top financial ministers and find a way for them to coalesce around joint challenges. With 20 countries, there are often differing opinions and factions. But this summit appeared to never have had much momentum. Even the simplest goals spurred divisions.

Before the U.S. attempted to gather the top attendees Monday for a "family photo," a tradition of such summits, the Europeans blanched. Ministers said they

wouldn't participate if the Russian finance minister was in the photo, people familiar with the matter said. They said they would send their deputies instead if the Russian official was part of the photo, one of the people said.

"The joint approach of the Europeans—for which I am also very grateful—ultimately led to this family photo taking place without the Russian finance minister, without the Russian delegation," German Finance Minister Lars Klingbeil told reporters.

At the press conference after the summit, Bessent said of the Russian minister's presence, "I know that some Europeans had a sour taste, but I think it's very important to engage."

Just as the meetings were getting started, Bessent had harsh words for Canada, saying it was impossible for the U.S. neighbor to be in a tit-for-tat trade war with "someone who's 13 times larger than you are." Bessent also joked that Canada might send mini-submarines previously used on an amusement-park ride to attack the U.S. The U.S. defense sec-

retary, Pete Hegseth, posted a photo on social media of two young women at a Canadian cadet training center that was interpreted as mocking their weight and gender.

"When the Americans stop doing memes, stop throwing shade, stop trying to be tough, and start being serious about having those discussions, we can have those discussions. But look, it's not constructive," Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney told reporters in Ottawa on Tuesday.

The Treasury Department didn't respond to repeated requests for comment about the summit.

Canadian Finance Minister François-Philippe Champagne said he met with Bessent Tuesday. "The message I am going to bring, of course, is that we are going to stand up for our workers," he told reporters before the meeting.

On Tuesday, Bessent lit into Iran, comparing it to a dying snake still wriggling after decapitation. The prolonged standoff between the U.S. and Iran has added to inflation and put bond markets on edge, and Bessent's comments suggest that the U.S. is willing to endure more economic pain to squeeze Tehran.

This annual summit has been showing signs of fraying for years. In 2025, Bessent skipped the finance ministers' meeting hosted by South Africa amid Trump's allegations that South Africa was confiscating land from white South Africans.

The Treasury secretary arrived making the case that the Trump administration was well on its way to fixing an American economy that he said had floundered under the Biden administration, and that other countries could thrive by following a similar deregulatory agenda.

"I say sometimes I feel like an emergency-room doctor, and the economy is the patient, and the American people were backed over by the Biden Mack truck," Bessent told reporters Monday. "We have stabilized the patient, and now we are in the healing portion."

The U.S. economy, however, has shown signs of strain. The U.S. government is running huge budget

deficits, gasoline prices are high, the labor market lost 23,000 jobs in July, and inflation is still above the Fed's target.

Bessent was joined at the summit by Federal Reserve Chairman Kevin Warsh, who faces a tough decision about whether to raise interest rates as soon as this month to combat inflation, despite Trump's demands for lower rates. Warsh has suggested the Fed might need to act, another factor pushing bond yields higher.

Leaders of two of America's biggest banks, Goldman Sachs's David Solomon and JPMorgan's Jamie Dimon, took part in a roundtable discussion with finance ministers on Monday. The Trump administration privately requested the executives discuss the state of the U.S. economy at the meeting, according to a person familiar with the matter.

Dimon, in a statement sent to reporters by G-20 organizers, cheered the invite. "For the first time at G-20, the Treasury has given the private sector a place at the table. Good policy is made better when those who lend, hire, invest and build have a voice in shaping it," Dimon said.

Solomon said in an interview with CNBC on the sidelines of the conference that his outlook is "pretty constructive" and that the "economy is performing well," noting headwinds with conflicts in the Middle East and trade wars.

Some executives who attended the summit and met with Bessent told their advisers that in private, Bessent made the case that the U.S. economy remains strong. He offered few new details or conclusions during the meetings on how the administration plans to handle Iran as well as a sluggish market, these people said.

The bond market, though, was casting its own verdict on the challenge governments are up against.

The market for U.S. Treasuries, long considered an ultra-safe asset by investors, was flashing a warning light. Short- and long-term yield benchmarks both set new 2026 highs Tuesday.

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Nepal seeks compensation from biggest GHG emitters

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Nepal is demanding climate compensation from the world's biggest emitters of greenhouse gases (GHG) after deadly floods in the country killed more than a thousand people and left even more missing.

China, the US and India have made "extremely large" contributions to climate change and left smaller nations "enduring the price of it," Nepal's foreign minister Shisir Khanal told Kantipur TV.

"Nepal must hold its head high internationally and turn this into a matter of justice," he said in the interview, which was broadcast earlier this week. "We will raise this matter explicitly and forcefully on international platforms."

Nepal's demand for climate compensation follows the 26 August flash floods in the Bhotekoshi River basin, triggered by a massive rock and ice collapse near the Nepal-Tibet border.

The official death toll has risen to 1,114, with nearly 4,000 people still missing, according to authorities, as floodwaters destroyed homes, key bridges and critical hydropower infrastructure.

The demand comes ahead



China, the US and India have made 'extremely large' contributions to climate change, said Nepal's foreign minister Shisir Khanal. AFP

of the United Nations' (UN) annual climate summit in November, where developing nations are expected to press wealthier, high-emitting countries for more funding to cover climate-related losses and damage.

Nepal's demand for compensation follows the 26 August flash floods in the Bhotekoshi River basin

Nepal's push adds to a broader debate over who should bear the financial cost of disasters linked to a warming planet.

"Nepal cannot reduce the world's emissions on behalf of the polluters."

It cannot protect the Himalayas through adaptation alone while the world continues to burn more fossil fuels," the Global Campaign to Demand Climate Justice, a civil society coalition of 200

international groups, said in a statement on Tuesday. "And it should not have to take on more debt to protect its people from a crisis overwhelmingly created elsewhere."

In the interview, Khanal said that Nepal has sought urgent relief from the UN's Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage, set up to help vulnerable countries recover from climate-related disasters. According to local media, officials said in a letter to the fund that recovery costs far exceed domestic resources and that waiting for its board to meet in December would be too late.

Representatives for Nepal's ministry of forests and environment and the UN's Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

US pounds Iran; Tehran strikes back at bases

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com
WASHINGTON/DUBAI

Iranians and their Arab neighbours feared a return of war on Wednesday after the biggest exchange of fire between Tehran and Washington since July, with US forces striking Iran's southern coast and Iran firing at American bases across the region.

The US threatened more devastating strikes. Iran accused Washington of hitting a wedding party, killing four people and wounding dozens. Asian and European stocks tumbled after the renewed US airstrikes, which pushed oil prices back up to levels unseen since July.

The US military said it struck air defences, radar systems, maritime assets, mine-laying capabilities and communications sites on Tuesday. Iran reported hits on multiple targets near the Strait of Hormuz.

"Last night was like the end of the world," Mahmoud, 38, a municipal worker in Sirik County along the strait, told Reuters by telephone, describing attacks on the area which includes the city where the wedding was reported to have been hit.

Iran responded by striking what it said were US assets in Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait and Iraq, and said its aim was now to drive US forces from the vast network of military bases they have occupied for decades across the Middle East.

"American evil in the region will be met with heavier, more



The US military said it struck air defences, radar systems, maritime assets and communications sites on Tuesday. AFP

widespread, and devastating responses, and any country that cooperates with the aggressive American army must accept its dangerous consequences," Iran's military command said.

Iran said it killed US forces in Jordan and at a base in northern Iraq, but US officials told Reuters there had not been any casualties, according to initial assessments.

In Kuwait, Iran said it had carried out a missile and drone attack on the vast US Ali Al Salem Air Base and targeted the accommodation of a U.S. commander. Kuwait's fire service said it put out a blaze at a residential complex hit by a drone.

Qatar, home of the largest US airbase in the Gulf, said it held Iran responsible for attacks and their repercussions. Bahrain, which houses the regional headquarters of the US Navy, said Iranian drones were intercepted and

destroyed.

Iran also said two tankers had been struck by mines while being steered through the Strait of Hormuz by US personnel.

Washington says that despite Iranian attacks, it is guiding ships through the strait. Energy secretary Chris Wright said more than 17 million barrels of oil exited on Monday.

Saudi Arabia's national shipping company reported on Wednesday that two Filipino crew had been killed aboard an oil tanker in the strait two days earlier. Iranians were fearful that the new strikes signalled war could restart at full throttle.

"It's very difficult to live like this. We don't know when America will strike. My family and I are constantly worried about where will it strike," Mahpari, 28, a woman in the southern port city of Bandar Abbas, told Reuters by phone.

Iran reported at least 12 deaths from the night of US strikes, with four people including a four-year-old said to have been killed while celebrating the wedding at a home in Sirik.

Earlier reports put the death toll there at five. Iranian media said as many as 68 people were wounded there, and released images of injured children in hospital.

Reuters was unable to independently verify the incident. US Navy Captain Tim Hawkins, a spokesperson for Central Command, said: "We are aware of reports, which originated from Iranian state

media. The US military never targets civilians, unlike the IRGC," referring to Iran's Revolutionary Guards.

Video filmed by Iran's West Asia News Agency at the purported site showed rubble strewn across rooms and a courtyard. A pair of strappy women's dress sandals lay abandoned on a blood-soaked carpet.

"I am just glad the casualties weren't even worse," said Ali Molahi, identified as the father of the bride. Iranian officials compared the incident to a strike on a girls' school that killed 160 people on the war's first night. The Pentagon has not released the findings of an investigation into that attack, which would be US military's largest civilian casualty incident in decades. The exchange of fire was the worst since July,

when US President Donald Trump abruptly halted two weeks of intense bombing of Iran after warnings from his military brass that they were using up munitions and running out of meaningful targets. Trump, who has yet to achieve the aims he set when launching "Operation Epic Fury" in February—to end Iran's nuclear programme, deprive it of the ability to strike its neighbours and create conditions for Iranians to topple their rulers—repeated his declarations that victory was at hand.

"I like our position now much better, with almost total control of the Hormuz Strait,

and their economy totally collapsing," he said on Tuesday.

Treasury secretary Scott Bessent said Washington was looking at targeting airlines, the maritime industry and

digital assets as part of a campaign to increase economic pressure on Tehran.

Sources have told Reuters Trump aides were trying to keep the war quiet for now to avert a rout in congressional elections in November. Polls show Americans oppose the war by more than a two-to-one margin. Iran, for its part, is determined to emerge from the war stronger than before, with sanctions lifted, blocked funds released, and a newfound grip over the strait letting it collect fees from ships that normally carry a fifth of global oil.



m
NEWS
NUMBERS

\$47 mn

THE COMPENSATION package of Tim Cook, Apple's former CEO, including \$2 million in annual salary and \$45 million in planned equity, as its executive chairman.

\$1 bn

THE AMOUNT for which Nestle is selling its vitamins, minerals and supplements business to Yellow Wood Partners to refocus its strategic portfolio.

31%

THE SHARE of households reporting that retail egg prices have increased by 25-50% over the past six months, according to a LocalCircles survey.

\$5 bn

THE BRAND value of Amul, according to Brand Finance's *Food & Drinks* 2026 report, up 22% from a year ago, making it the world's strongest dairy brand.

601 mn

THE NUMBER of credit card transactions recorded in July in India, up 241% year-on-year, while the average transaction value fell 13.5% during the same period.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

BSE seeks high frequency traders' support



The closing auction system has faced hiccups since its 3 August launch.

REUTERS

BSE Ltd is engaging with high-frequency traders (HFT) and other market participants to boost day-end trading volumes after thin liquidity under the newly introduced closing auction system (CAS)

triggered sharp price swings. HFT firms, proprietary traders and retail investors are not participating as they "seem to be not seeing benefit of this system," Sundararaman Ramamurthy, chief executive officer and managing director at the oldest Indian bourse operator, said in an interview Wednesday with local television channel Zee Business.

"We are talking to them as their participation will only make CAS a success," Ramamurthy said. "Some minor changes will always be considered to make the system more efficient."

The new method—rolled out to align Indian markets with major global peers—has faced hiccups since its 3 August launch, with the latest index rebalancing witnessing sharp swings in most stocks. The mechanism has also shrunk options turnover at BSE and its listing-bound larger rival National Stock Exchange of India Ltd.

BLOOMBERG



ISTOCKPHOTO

Global warming to exceed 1.5° Celsius limit soon, says UN

Officials say the world must figure out how to get temperatures below the danger zone

AP
feedback@livemint.com
WASHINGTON

In a strategic retreat in the fight against climate change, the United Nations (UN) has acknowledged that Earth has lost its chance to prevent some of the worst of global warming's harms. So now the world must figure out how to get temperatures below the danger zone and back to safety, officials say.

Earth is soon going to exceed the safe temperature threshold agreed upon by the world in the 2015 Paris climate accord because of warming from the burning of coal, oil and gas, according to a first-of-its-kind report issued by the United Nations Environment Programme on Wednesday. Instead of giving up, scientists and UN officials recommend trying to limit excessive warming and then bring the temperature back down to the agreed-upon threshold. But it still will mean decades of increased weather-related disasters, rising seas, extinctions and melting ice and glaciers.

"Humanity is speeding past the limit to avoid climate catastrophe," UN secretary-general António Guterres said.

After a period of over-the-limit warming,

the new strategy envisions getting back below the limit by ending fossil fuel use and developing some kind of way to suck industries' carbon dioxide out of the air.

After the Paris climate accord, the UN ordered its climate science arm to study different warming limits. A goal of 1.5° Celsius above mid-19th century temperatures became generally accepted after the scientists found dramatic impacts that affect people and the planet at 2° Celsius but not at 1.5°.

The world is now at 1.4° Celsius above pre-industrial levels, some scientists have calculated. The measure is based on a 20-year average, rather than a single year's temperatures.

Despite experts saying there's no way to limit warming to 1.5°, UN officials long maintained the 1.5° window was still open. Wednesday's report finally admitted that the world will cross the 1.5° threshold "in the next few years."

The report said the most optimistic scenario has warming peaking at 1.8° Celsius around mid-century if countries pursue ambitious climate goals, but that governments' current policies should push temperatures to 2.6° above pre-industrial levels by 2100.

Merchant banking permit for Zerodha

A unit of Zerodha Broking Ltd, India's second-largest broker founded by billionaire Nithin Kamath, secured a merchant banking license as the nation's booming equity capital market draws new entrants seeking a share of record fees. Zerodha Corporate Advisors received approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India on Wednesday, according to the regulator's website. The licence allows the firm to advise on and manage initial public offerings and other capital-market transactions, expanding the financial-services group's presence beyond broking. The firm plans to start operations over the next couple of months, said Mohit Mehra, whole-time director at Zerodha.

BLOOMBERG



Tarun Garg said India needs to accelerate efforts to build domestic capabilities in critical tech.

MINT

Hyundai's Garg urges consistent policy

Hyundai Motor India Ltd managing director (MD) and chief executive officer (CEO) Tarun Garg on Wednesday called for a consistent long-term policy framework to support scale and accelerate technology and component development, while urging the country's auto industry to move beyond exporting conventional components to advanced technologies, engineering capabilities and innovation.

Addressing the 66th Annual Session of the Automotive Component Manufacturers Association of India (Acma), Garg said India needs to accelerate efforts to build domestic capabilities in critical technologies such as semiconductor chips, battery cells for electric vehicles, and power electronics.

"The government on its part needs to provide consistent long-term policy that supports scale and accelerates the development of technologies and components," he said.

Garg observed that the time has come for India to progress from exporting conventional components to exporting advanced technologies, engineering capability and innovation.

PTI

Jaishankar to visit Ukraine, Poland

External affairs minister S. Jaishankar will undertake a three-day visit to Ukraine and Poland beginning Thursday amid escalating hostilities between Moscow and Kyiv. In Kyiv, Jaishankar is expected to press for finding a peaceful resolution to the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

The ministry of external affairs said Jaishankar will hold bilateral consultations with his Ukrainian counterpart Andriy Sybiba and Polish deputy prime minister Radoslaw Sikorski. "The visit will focus on enhancing bilateral relations and also provide an opportunity to exchange views on regional developments and issues of mutual interest," the ministry said in a statement.

PTI



The cargo handled by India's largest port operator rose 19% to 50 mt in August.

AFP

APSEZ hits record cargo mark in Aug

Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) handled a record 50 million tonnes (mt) of cargo in August, its highest monthly throughput to date, as stronger domestic economic activity, rising container trade and a diversified cargo mix lifted volumes.

The cargo handled by India's largest port operator rose 19% from 41.9 million tonnes a year earlier, according to the company.

The increase comes as India's economy continues to expand even as geopolitical tensions, shifting shipping routes and supply-chain realignments reshape global trade flows.

The growth was broad-based. Dry cargo volumes rose 25% year-on-year in August, while container volumes increased 15%. Shipments of commodities, including coal, iron ore, limestone and other minerals, also contributed to the increase. International operations added to the gains, with Australia's North Queensland Export Terminal contributing to volumes and Colombo West International Terminal in Sri Lanka continuing its ramp-up. Existing assets, including Mundra in Gujarat, Krishnapatnam in Andhra Pradesh and the port of Dar es Salaam in Tanzania, also recorded growth.

PTI

UltraTech to add 500 e-trucks by Dec



The cement maker operates one of India's most complex logistics networks.

REUTERS

Leading cement maker UltraTech on Wednesday said it will scale up its electric vehicle (EV) fleet in logistics operations to over 600 trucks by December from 100 vehicles currently.

This move is expected to help the Aditya Birla Group flagship firm to transport

about five million tonnes of clinker and to enable a net annual reduction of over 117,000 tonnes of carbon dioxide, equivalent to displacing 39 million litres of diesel per year, according to a statement.

"UltraTech has signed service contracts with leading EV prime mover manufacturers including Tata Motors, Ashok Leyland, IPLTech, Energy in Motion and Sany along with their subsidiaries and other third-party logistic providers to deploy EV trucks," the company said. This fleet of over 600 e-trucks will operate across Gujarat, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra and Odisha, transporting clinker and other key materials, the company said.

UltraTech, with a grey cement capacity of over 200 million tonnes per annum, operates one of India's most complex logistics networks. Its electrification strategy covers the entire supply chain.

PTI

Debt fundraising halves in August

Indian corporate bond issuance is unlikely to rebound in September after debt fundraising nearly halved month-on-month in August, with a spike in yields reducing incentive for firms to lock in borrowing, keeping primary-market activity subdued.

Indian companies raised around ₹61,760 crore through private placement of bonds in August, according to data from Prime Database. The quantum witnessed a 45% drop as compared to July, while yields rose across the curve mainly led by the shorter end. Liquidity by itself will not translate to stronger corporate bond fundraising which is one of the reasons issuance has been moderating, said Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, founder and managing partner of debt advisory firm Rockfort Fincap.

Firms had raised ₹113 trillion and ₹116 trillion in June and July, in the background of easing crashed after central bank's dollar-attracting measures in June.

REUTERS

Purple Style IPO sees 1.29x subscription

The initial public offering (IPO) of Purple Style Labs Ltd, the parent company of Pernia's Pop-Up Shop, received 1.29 times subscription on the final day on Wednesday.

The company's IPO got bids for 8.86 million shares against 6.84 million shares on offer, as per details available with the National Stock Exchange. The portion for retail investors received 1.58 times subscription, while the category for qualified institutional buyers was subscribed 1.43 times. The quota for non-institutional investors got subscribed 84%.

Purple Style Labs on Friday raised ₹306 crore from anchor investors.

The public offer comprises entirely a fresh issue of equity shares aggregating up to ₹680 crore. The price band for the IPO has been fixed at ₹546-575 per share. At the upper end of the price band, the issue values Purple Style Labs at a market capitalization of over ₹4,600 crore.

PTI



Range Rover plans to build up to 15,000 units of the new electric vehicle over the next six months.

JLR launches first electric Range Rover

One year after a major cyberattack halted production and hit its finances, British carmaker Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) on Wednesday opened orders for a new fully electric Range Rover.

The timing of the launch was a "coincidence", JLR chief operating officer Nigel Blenkinsop told AFP, adding that the firm had "recovered really, really strongly." He said the carmaker had "brought production back up to normal levels really, really quickly post the incident."

JLR, owned by India's Tata Motors, revealed at the start of September 2025 that it had been targeted by hackers, forcing it to halt production for more than one month and costing the company £196 million (\$264 million).

The launch of the electric Range Rover is a major strategic issue for the brand, which plans to build between 12,000 and 15,000 units over the next six months.

AFP

Reliance unit gets USFDA warning

The United States Food and Drug Administration (USFDA) has issued a warning letter to Reliance Life Sciences Pvt. Ltd over "significant violations" of current good manufacturing practice (CGMP) regulations for finished pharmaceuticals at its manufacturing facility in Navi Mumbai.

The USFDA inspected the Dhirubhai Ambani Life Sciences Centre in Navi Mumbai from 19-27 February, the regulator said. In its warning letter, the USFDA said the firm failed to ensure laboratory records included complete data from all tests necessary to ensure compliance with established specifications and standards.

It added that Reliance Life Sciences failed to establish and follow appropriate written procedures designed to "prevent microbiological contamination of drug products purporting to be sterile and that include validation of all aseptic and sterilisation processes."

PTI

BP names Ian Tyler as new chairman

BP Plc named Ian Tyler chairman following an interim stint in the role, ending a period of boardroom drama and allowing chief executive officer (CEO) Meg O'Neill to continue reshaping the company.

The move cements O'Neill's control of the London-based oil major after she joined the company in April as Big Oil's first female CEO. BP's first outsider hired for the top job has moved quickly to reorganize the company, selling low-returning assets and streamlining the corporate structure.

Tyler, previously chair of Cairn Energy Plc, has a reputation for being collegiate, a contrast with the tensions that contributed to the ouster of his predecessor Albert Manifold in May. He is currently chairman of Grafton Group Plc, a senior independent director of Anglo American Plc, and joined BP's board in 2025.

Manifold was fired just eight months into the role after he was brought in to turn around the struggling oil major.

BLOOMBERG

Anthropic says new Fable AI model is cheaper, better at coding

Anthropic PBC is releasing a new version of its powerful Fable artificial intelligence (AI) model that it says is better at coding and science tasks, as well as more economical—all changes it says are in response to customer feedback.

The company said Fable 5.1, which released on Tuesday, is more skilled at carrying out lengthy, complicated computer programming tasks, such as software projects or code reviews that require it to work across all the code for an application. The new version is also better at helping with scientific work like coming up with experiment designs, simulating what could happen during an experiment and reading information in dense diagrams and tables, Anthropic said.

Companies are increasingly trying to justify and rein in the costs for AI usage at a time when open-weight, lower cost models from China are rapidly improving. These trends are applying pressure to US-based model makers like Anthropic.



Companies are increasingly trying to rein in AI usage costs.

REUTERS



BEYOND PRESTIGE: UNPACKING SOVEREIGN RATINGS

Rather than treat a sovereign rating as a badge of national prestige, it is more useful to engage with its many dimensions

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In August, Fitch Ratings reaffirmed India's long-term sovereign risk rating at 'BBB-' with a stable outlook—a rating level India has held for 20 years. This is a notch lower than the 'BBB' and 'Baa3' ratings assigned by S&P Global and Moody's, respectively.

On the Fitch ratings scale, India is at the minimum investment grade, any lower and it would fall into the speculative category. The other two rating agencies place India a notch above investment grade.

India's prolonged stay at the minimum investment grade rating level has come in for much discussion. An often-heard view is that the country is rated harshly by global credit rating agencies given its size, economic growth and political stability. What methodology do these rating agencies follow for sovereign ratings? Does that methodology faithfully capture what it sets out to capture? Where does India fare well and where does it lag? Are ratings the start and end point of this conversation, or is there more?

SERVICING DEBT

A sovereign rating is the opinion of a rating agency on a nation's ability and willingness to service its debt obligations. Ratings are represented by symbols ranging from D (default grade, worst rating) to AAA (highest rating). India's BBB lies somewhere in the middle. Plus (+) and minus (-) symbols are added to indicate tiers within each rating category.

A sovereign's ability to pay is gauged by assessing if its revenue generating capacity is enough to service its debt. In order to make this evaluation, rating agencies analyse metrics on growth, per capita GDP, debt, fiscal balance, external vulnerability, inflation and monetary management. Willingness to repay is assessed on the basis of qualitative factors such as political stability, prevalence of rule of law, civil society activity, and the credibility and independence of institutions—all fairly subjective in nature.

S&P Global, the largest of the big three international rating agencies, bases its sovereign ratings on five assessment pillars: institutional, economic, external, fiscal and monetary factors. Each is assigned a value on a scale of 1 to 6, with 6 being the weakest. These are then combined and adjusted to generate a final rating. Other rating agencies follow a broadly similar methodology.

A BBB rating, which India has, implies the country has adequate capacity to repay debt, but faces moderate economic vulnerability. In effect, the BBB group includes countries that are stable enough to avoid default, yet are sensitive to major shocks. As of end-July, there were 25 countries in S&P's BBB universe.

The group is fairly diverse. It includes Asian emerging market peers such as Thailand, Philippines, Indonesia; some emerging European economies, including Hungary, Bulgaria and Serbia; Mexico, Uruguay and Paraguay from the Americas, and Morocco from North Africa. The list also includes two distinctly richer countries: Italy and Sharjah, one of the seven emirates that constitute the UAE. The GDP per capita of this set of 25 countries ranges from \$2,810 (India) to \$46,710 (British Virgin Islands).

MIX AND MATCH

There is no unique combination of attributes to achieve a BBB (or any other) rating. Countries within the same rating category have distinct economic, political, socio-institutional and geopolitical profiles. Consider India and Italy, which are both in the BBB group, despite their very different economic structures (strictly speaking, S&P rates Italy as BBB+, India as BBB; Fitch rates Italy as BBB+ and India as BBB-).

Over the last three years, India has grown at 6-7% a year, while Italy grew at less than 1%. India runs a current account deficit, while Italy has a surplus. Italy's per capita GDP is 17 times India's. Yet, Italy is assessed to be weaker on the external front because of its huge government debt (133% of GDP versus 80% for India), and large external creditor position to the rest of the world. India's low external debt partially makes up for other weaknesses in its economic profile.

Differences like this create distinct economic vulnerabilities across the group.

There is evidence that sovereign ratings are biased against developing nations, with assessments based on qualitative indices that are highly subjective.

making; India is a democracy with a federal structure. That explains why Sharjah scores worse than India on S&P's monetary and institutional assessments. Consequently, in spite of having a per capita GDP that is 10x of India, Sharjah and India have identical sovereign ratings.

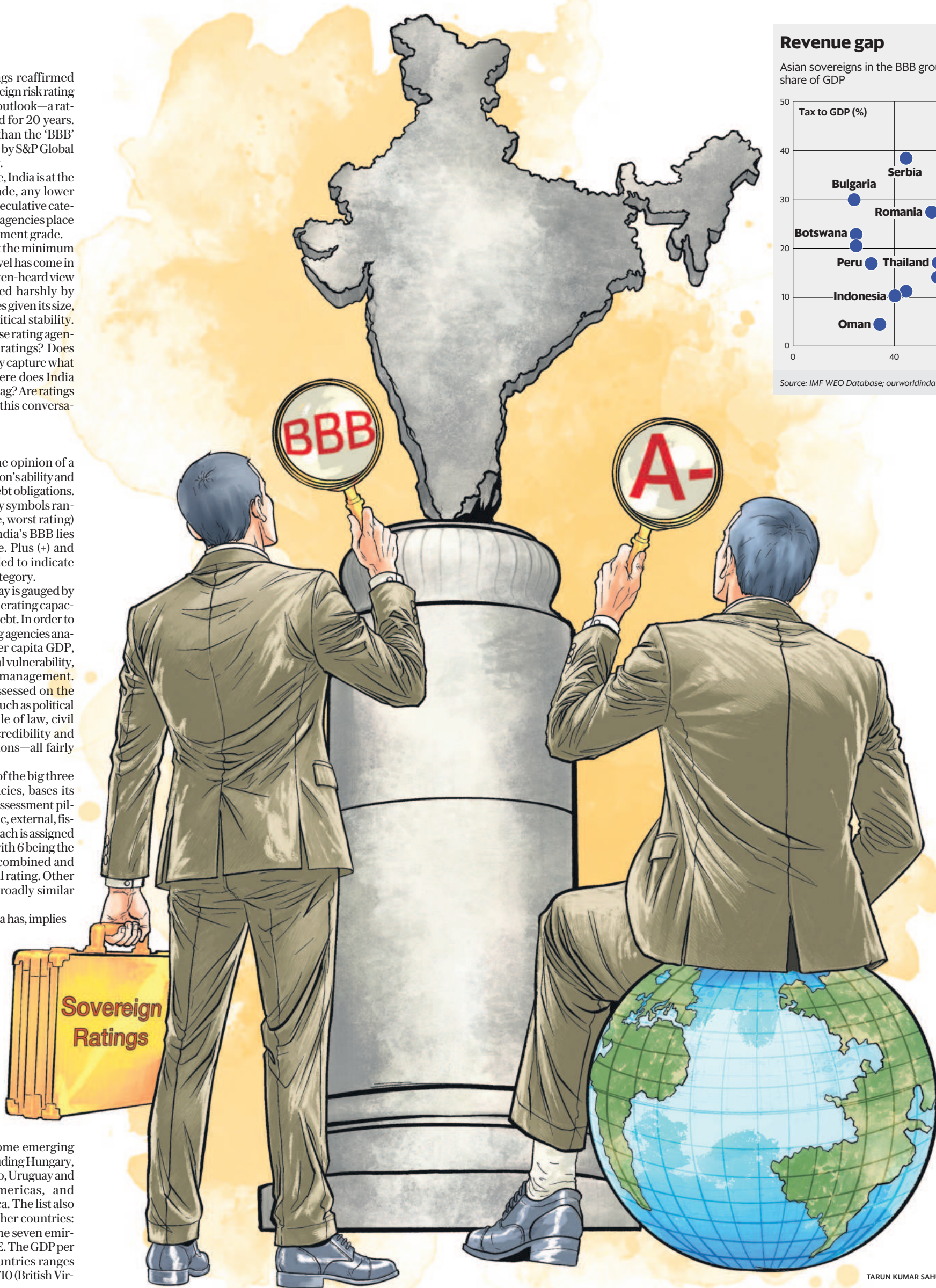
The takeaway is that a sovereign credit rating is not simply a measure of how

strong or rich an economy is. Rather, it is a composite measure of several elements that affect a country's ability to service its debt obligations. Therefore, instead of treating a sovereign rating as a badge of national prestige, it is more useful to engage with it along five key dimensions.

PER CAPITA DYNAMICS

One, real per capita GDP (in US dollars) is a vital input to the rating process. Countries with higher per capita GDP tend to cluster in higher rating categories. The connection is straightforward: higher per capita income reflects a higher standard of living, which means a government has a large base to draw tax revenues from. This, in turn, makes it more credit-worthy.

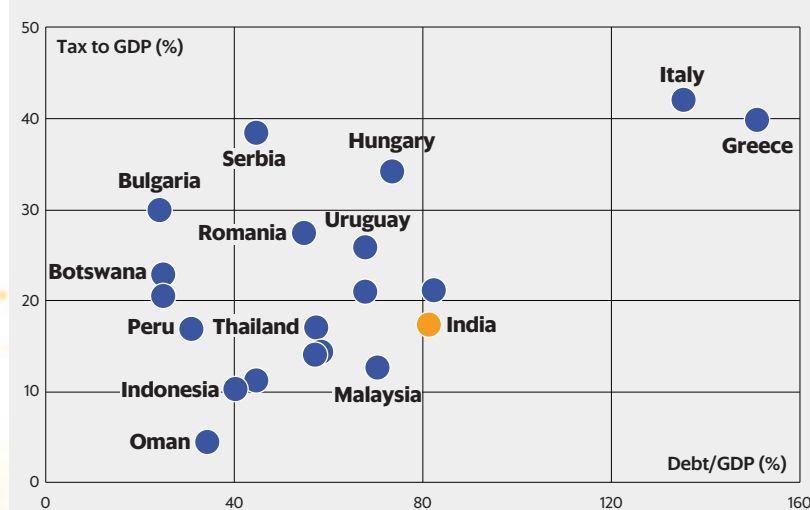
This reliance on per capita GDP in dollars is often criticized by Indian experts because per capita GDP in purchasing power parity (PPP) terms better reflects the comparatively lower prices of goods and services in developing countries. Further, given the steady depreciation of the rupee, converting nominal GDP to dollars at market exchange rates understates the actual purchasing power of residents. That's why rating agencies attempt to



TARUN KUMAR SAHU/MINT

Revenue gap

Asian sovereigns in the BBB group tend to collect lower tax revenues as a share of GDP



Source: IMF WEO Database; ourworldindata.org

mint

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Vietnam (rated BB+, GDP per capita of \$5,100) are examples of emerging market peers that are richer than India but have not yet made it to investment grade.

FOCUS ON FUNDAMENTALS

Three, overall, sovereign ratings change slowly. Downgrades can be swift, but only when there is a crisis with a severe impact on creditworthiness. For instance, Thailand dropped from A to BBB after the Asian financial crisis in 1997. Italy suffered a similar downgrade in 2011-12 during the European debt crisis. But upgrades come on the back of many years of proven, sustained improvement across economic and institutional parameters.

Between 2005 and 2010, China was upgraded massively, moving from the BBB group to the AA group, because it had implemented banking reforms, built massive reserves, diversified export markets and delivered average growth of over 10% in the preceding two decades. India can possibly achieve the same if it continues to deliver strong growth.

Four, fiscal performance is a core driver of sovereign creditworthiness. Fiscal strength is usually assessed along two broad dimensions: debt burden and ability to service it via revenues. The first parameter analyses trends in general government debt by issuer (centre, states, municipalities), type (external or domestic), tenure (short or long term), and measure (value or percent to GDP). The second examines debt affordability by comparing debt service outflows to revenues or GDP. The lower the debt burden, and the higher the revenues available to service the debt, the more the fiscal flexibility.

To be sure, staying on a fiscally prudent path is necessary, and India's fiscal discipline has earned much praise among rating agencies. But a comparison of tax revenue to government debt shows the stark divide between emerging nations in Asia and Europe. Within the BBB group, the tax-to-GDP ratio ranges from 27-42% for European nations; but 4-20% for Asian sovereigns.

Even with relatively lower public debt, countries such as India, Indonesia and Mexico are fiscally vulnerable for two reasons: low tax collections and high ratio of interest payments to GDP. The former makes it harder to keep debt down and/or repay outstanding debt, and the latter reduces public funds available for investment and welfare spending. But this is not an insurmountable problem. As a recent opinion piece in *Mint* by economist Prachi Mishra pointed out, improving tax compliance by simplifying GST, improving state fiscal discipline by deepening the market for state loans, and committing to meet the goals of the new debt-anchored fiscal framework are some ways in which India can strengthen its fiscal position.

RATING REVIEW

Five, there is some evidence that sovereign ratings are biased against developing countries. The biases creep in at multiple levels. Some of the assessed parameters (say, governance) rely on qualitative indices that are highly subjective. But studies show that even measurable parameters are applied and interpreted differently for developing and developed countries.

For instance, the level of forex reserves is seen as being more important for developing countries, according to a 2025 UNC-TAD policy review titled 'Credit Rating Agencies, Developing Countries and Bias'.

mint
KEY
NUMBERS

25

Number of countries in the BBB universe of S&P Global, the largest rating agency, as of end-July.

\$2,810

India's GDP per capita, the lowest in S&P's BBB universe. The highest is British Virgin Islands' \$46,710.

27-42%

The tax-to-GDP ratio range for European nations in the BBB group. It is 4-20% for Asian sovereigns.

strike a balance between using nominal and PPP values: dollar GDP data is used to assess creditworthiness, while PPP data measures domestic economic progress. In addition, GDP is analysed from several angles: growth, volatility, and concentration. Sustained, strong growth is seen as a clear positive.

Two, low per capita income is not a bar to achieving an investment grade rating, as pointed out in an August 2026 S&P Global research note titled 'Do Low Income Block Sovereigns from Attaining Investment-Grade Ratings?' When India first attained investment grade (BBB-) in 2017, its per capita GDP was \$2,614 (adjusted to 2026 dollars)—much lower than the \$38,749 median for countries in that category. "India's per capita income remains the lowest among investment-grade sovereigns, despite many years of rapid GDP growth... India's strong external profile, record of above-average GDP growth, and good monetary policy flexibility balance its fiscal inflexibility, high debt burden, and low per capita GDP," says the note.

At the same time, all nations with speculative-grade ratings are not poor. Brazil (rated BB, GDP per capita of \$12,335) and



Foreign degrees on Indian campuses: will they deliver?

The cost advantage is clear, but employer acceptance and career outcomes remain untested

Ann Jacob
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MUMBAI

Earlier, pursuing an international degree meant paying not just lakhs in fees, but also expensive visas, living costs, airfares and other expenses that could add up to crores.

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 created a third option between domestic and overseas degrees by allowing foreign universities to set up branch campuses in India.

These operate under two regulatory gateways—the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) GIFT City framework under the ministry of finance and University Grants Commission (UGC) regulations under the ministry of education. Both restrict entry to institutions ranked among the top 500 in subject-wise global rankings by recognised ranking agencies worldwide. The *Gen Z Outlook Report 2026*, by online education company Emeritus, found that while 60% of pre-college students are interested in studying abroad, 69% of students seeking postgraduate programmes would prefer an India-based international programme to avoid growing visa-related uncertainty and delays.

Yet satellite campuses of foreign universities remain in their infancy, putting parents and experts in wait-and-watch mode.

Cost advantage

Ashwin Damera, co-founder and CEO of Emeritus, said the appeal of an Indian branch campus lies in significantly lower costs without sacrificing degree legitimacy. The campuses teach a curriculum similar to the home institutions, with degrees typically awarded by the parent university. Students may also retain access to exchanges and semester-abroad options.

A one-year postgraduate programme at the University of Liverpool's home campus costs roughly ₹30,000 in tuition (up to ₹38 lakh), plus ₹15,000 (₹19 lakh) in living costs—more than ₹60 lakh in all. Its India campus charges ₹14-15 lakh, plus local living expenses, cutting overall expenditure by roughly two-thirds.

For a four-year bachelor's programme, Damera cited Illinois Tech, where the total overseas cost is about \$200,000, or nearly ₹2 crore. Its Mumbai campus charges ₹40-50 lakh, including accommodation—about a quarter of the overseas cost—while allowing up to two semesters abroad under the same fee structure.

Damera added that campuses follow a 50:50 faculty structure, with international visiting and locally recruited faculty. Home campuses, he noted, offer broader electives and better local industry networks.

Credibility questions

Education counsellors urge families to look beyond the foreign brand. Bakhtawar Krishnan, an independent education counsellor (IEC), said satellite campuses address headwinds such as US visa rejections, Canada's international intake cuts and soaring Australian visa fees, but other uncertainties around these campuses still remain.

"Outside the graduates of Deakin University in Gujarat, there is no long-term placement data to prove how international employers will value a degree completed at a satellite campus versus a main campus. The campus environment will consist almost entirely of domestic

Satellite campuses: big savings, but the jury is out

New regulations allow eligible international institutions to set up campuses in India. While this can cut costs significantly, experts advise a wait-and-watch approach.

Cost comparison

	Study abroad (main campus)	India satellite campus
Total cost	₹60 lakh-₹2 crore (1-4 year courses)	₹14-50 lakh (1-4 year courses)
Visa fees	High visa fees, tightening visa rules	No visa requirement
Faculty mix	Fully international faculty	Foreign and local faculty in a 50:50 mix
Exposure	Diverse, global and multicultural	Primarily Indian students
Recruiters	Wider pool of global enterprises, regional networks	Typically mid-tier firms, early-stage startups

Source: Emeritus, Mint Research

Cost math

1-year master's degree (University of Liverpool)		4-year bachelor's degree (Illinois Institute of Technology)	
UK campus	Up to ₹60 lakh	US campus	Up to \$200,000 (up to ₹2 crore)
Tuition fees	£30,000 (up to ₹38 lakh)	4-year tuition fees	\$140,000 (around ₹33 lakh per year)
Living and travel	£15,000 (up to ₹19 lakh)	4-year living expenses	\$60,000 (over ₹14 lakh per year)
Satellite campus	Up to ₹14-15 lakh	Satellite campus	Up to ₹40-50 lakh overall (with accommodation)

Note: Up to 2 semesters abroad included under the local fee structure; Source: Emeritus

Parent perspectives



AMI GOEL (46)
Mumbai, Business owner

“The real question is if the additional cost translates into employability, international exposure, and alumni networks.”



ARUN JAIN (48)
Navi Mumbai, Insurance consultant

“These are early days and waters are yet to be tested. Hype needs to be segregated from the true value of global education.”

Student and parent checklist

- Verify:** Confirm approval under the applicable regulatory framework.
- Degree value:** Ensure the degree certificate is identical to that of the main campus.
- Faculty:** Understand the ratio of local faculty to visiting foreign professors.
- Exchanges:** Ensure semester-abroad guarantees come without hidden fees.
- Infrastructure:** Visit the actual operational campuses and their facilities.

Key risks

- Limited regulations:** No mandate for foreign faculty to teach on campus
- Employability:** Employers remain in wait-and-watch mode
- Infrastructure:** New campuses may operate out of commercial properties

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Indian students, removing the cross-cultural exposure that traditional study-abroad programs provide,” she noted.

Dr. Hareesh N. Ramanathan, the director of international relations and associate professor at CUSAT, said satellite campuses globally have faced perceptions of being ‘second-tier.’ He also noted that regulations do not mandate student recruitment standards, faculty pay scales or how frequently parent-institution professors must teach on campus.

Employer test

Suchindra Kumar, partner and sector leader for education at PwC, said employers remain cautious. “Some of the employers that we have spoken to are in a wait-and-watch mode about the outcome,” said Kumar. “The larger companies in India already have pretty good relationships with established campuses. It is still too early for them to switch over to a campus that is untested. Maybe two to three years down the line, things will start looking up.”

“From what we understand, none of the large employers have hired from

there. It is mostly mid-tier consulting firms and startups who have recruited; bigger brands kept their distance.”

Parents hold back

Foreign satellite campuses offer a third path between domestic universities and expensive overseas education, but parents remain cautious.

Amit Goel, a business owner planning for his daughter's education, said: “I

would not look at it simply as paying a premium for a foreign degree. The real question for me is whether the additional cost translates into better learning, employability, international exposure, industry access, future mobility, alumni networks and more.”

Arun Jain, an insurance consultant, who is planning for his child's education, said: “These are early days for foreign campuses here. Waters are yet to be tested; hype and euphoria must be segregated from true value of global education.”

Financial check

Preeti Zende, a Securities and Exchange Board of India-registered investment advisor and founder of

Apna Dhan Financial Services, said: “Sometimes with such private universities, the course fee must be elevated to offset local infrastructure costs. We really need to see the cost breakdown. For those looking at education loans, we also need to evaluate how Indian banks will look at these institutions. Banks look closely at employability before underwriting loans.”

Experts advise families to verify the regulatory framework and that the degree is identical to the main campus. They should also check the local-to-foreign faculty ratio, how often foreign professors teach on campus, and whether exchange and transfer options are guaranteed within the quoted fee structure.

Satellite campuses lower the cost of a global degree, but employer acceptance and career outcomes are uncertain. Parents should scrutinize fees and look beyond foreign brand value.



Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

Beyond prestige: unpacking sovereign ratings

FROM PAGE 10

In the same way, a worsening of fiscal balance or inflation has a greater negative impact on developing economies. These differences in interpretation have real and significant consequences. An emerging economy may choose to hold excessively high reserves, or keep fiscal policy unnecessarily tight, just to avoid a ratings downgrade.

Emerging economies are increasingly questioning the ratings assigned by international agencies, often by setting up an equivalent domestic agency. India joined the club in 2024 with CareEdge Global Ratings, which offers a differentiated approach to sovereign ratings. Its methodology focuses on assessing sovereign credit strength by evaluating quantitative parameters such as indicators of capital formation, size and growth of the economy, debt sustainability, and external vulnerability. CareEdge currently rates India at BBB- with a stable outlook, a notch or two higher than the big three. It is a sobering reality that in spite of CareEdge's quantitative methodology, India's sovereign rating saw



In August, Fitch Ratings reaffirmed India's long-term sovereign risk rating at 'BBB-' with a stable outlook. BLOOMBERG

only a small upgrade.

The good news for India is that global investors do not rely solely on ratings. They take many factors into account, which are often more important than the sovereign rating. Apart from passive bond funds, which are required to follow ratings norms of the index they are tracking, investors are more likely to track market indicators such as credit default swaps (CDS), which provide a real-time assessment of default risk.

At a session on sovereign ratings at the Raisina Dia-

logues conference earlier this year, experts opined that the pricing of India's sovereign debt was more aligned to an A-minus rating, suggesting that markets place it in a higher rating category. Indeed, if a country has robust systems for collecting and sharing data, and manages its fiscal position prudently and transparently, investors are less likely to depend on sovereign ratings. A sovereign rating may be a starting point, but it is not the last word on a nation's creditworthiness.

howindialives.com is a search engine for public data.

Compare NRE FD rates

Non-resident Indians (NRIs) can open NRE fixed deposits with different Indian banks. The benefit of an NRE deposit is that it can be opened simply by making inward remittance to India in any freely convertible currency. Another benefit is that the interest earned on NRE deposits are tax-free and the deposit is fully repatriable, allowing NRIs to transfer funds back to their country of residence without restrictions. NRE FDs can be opened and managed online too with Indian banks. NRIs can also obtain loan against NRE FDs which can be used for a variety of purposes. These loans can be granted to the NRI in India or outside India (by overseas branch of Indian banks) or even to third parties.



NRE Term Deposits Interest Rates (%) upto ₹1 crore				
	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.90-7.10	6.90-7.50	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.50
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	6.55-6.60	6.75-7.05	6.80	6.85
YES Bank	6.65-7.25	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	7.00-7.20	7.20	7.00-7.20	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.60-7.25	7.00	6.70	6.70
IndusInd Bank	6.75-6.90	7.00	6.65-7.00	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	6.25-7.10	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.25	6.50-6.60
Axis Bank	6.25-6.50	6.50	6.50	6.50
ICICI Bank	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
Federal Bank	6.25-6.60	6.40-6.50	6.50-6.70	6.00
City Union Bank	6.50-7.25	6.50	6.50-6.55	6.25-6.55
Canara Bank	6.25-6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.35-6.55	6.80	6.40	6.25
HDFC Bank	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	6.40-6.60	6.40	6.10	6.10
State Bank of India	6.25-6.45	6.15	6.00	6.05

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 1 September 2026; Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

mint

Source: BankBazaar

IS YOUR PORTFOLIO TOO HEAVY ON EQUITY? WHAT INVESTORS SHOULD DO NOW



POWER POINT
JOYDEEP SEN

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

Investment professionals and financial planners have long advocated diversified portfolios. Investors who work with financial advisors and follow their advice will generally have reasonably balanced portfolios. DIY (do-it-yourself) investors, however, tend to chase returns, allocating more to asset classes that have delivered higher returns or those they are more comfortable with. For many, that asset class is equity. More conservative investors, or those yet to venture into equities, tend to favour fixed-income products such as fixed deposits. The practical implications of an equity-heavy portfolio merit examination.

Current situation

Since the peak in September 2024, Indian equity markets, measured by the Nifty 50 and Sensex, have delivered negative returns of roughly 7-8%. There is no fundamental question over the long-term growth prospects of the Indian economy or corporate sector. And over the long history of equity markets, corrections of 30-50% are not unusual. Data shows that even after such

corrections, investors who stayed invested have, over time, earned decent returns.

Equity-market corrections broadly take two forms: price and time. A price correction is a sharp fall in prices, say 30-50%. A time correction occurs when the market goes nowhere for an extended period—perhaps a year or several years—leaving investors with little or no return, or returns lower than what a bank fixed deposit might offer. The current phase is closer to a time correction. Returns have been negative, but the decline has not been particularly deep. The key question, therefore, is how long it takes for the market and earnings to regain momentum.

Concentration risk

For equity-heavy investors, this is a time for review and reflection. As history shows, both price and time corrections are part of investing. The question is whether you want a smoother investment journey or are comfortable with the bumps along the way. Over the past one-and-a-half to two years, an investor with a properly diversified portfolio spanning equity, fixed income, gold and other asset classes, based on their profile and objectives, would have earned decent positive returns. The basic premise of market-based investing is that returns come with risk: the higher the risk, the higher the expected return. The important word is “expected”, not guaranteed. Higher risk also means a greater possibility of falling short of the expected return.

Cryptocurrency is an extreme illustration of the high-risk, high-return proposition. At one point, Bitcoin delivered spectacular returns, but the risk was equally high. With no underlying cash flows or earnings to anchor its value in the way there are for



equities, its price depends heavily on expectations of future demand and appreciation. After a correction, investors who bought at high prices can remain stuck with steep losses.

At best, Bitcoin warranted only an allocation that an investor could afford to ignore without losing sleep. That is not to equate equity with Bitcoin. Equity has a fundamental basis in the growth and profitability of the underlying businesses. The broader point is that every asset class—equity, fixed income, gold and others—has a history of adverse phases.

One way of assessing this risk is through drawdown: how much an asset loses from a peak during a bad phase. As an illustration

from the not-too-distant past, equity markets fell roughly 38% between January and 23 March 2020, at the index level.

These are paper losses until an investor sells, but the size of a potential drawdown provides a useful perspective on how much space an asset class should occupy in a portfolio. Investors, particularly those without professional advice, look at recent returns and immediate prospects while underestimating the range of outcomes over a full market cycle.

No asset class consistently outperforms forever, making diversification a sensible choice

Stay the course—or diversify

If you are convinced that an equity-heavy portfolio suits you, have a sufficiently long investment horizon—say, 10 years or more—and are comfortable with periodic price and time corrections, staying the course make sense. But if you accept the conventional wisdom that nobody knows the future or precisely how much any asset class will return, a balanced and diversified portfolio is more appropriate. This is particularly relevant for relatively new investors who have not experienced a major market correction. A 30-50% fall can look like just another statistic until you experience its impact on your portfolio.

History also shows that no single asset class—equity, debt or gold—has consistently outperformed year after year. Unless you have become overly committed to one particular asset class, a “balanced diet” remains a sensible approach to investing.

Joydeep Sen is a corporate trainer specialising in financial markets and author.

OUR VIEW



Personal guarantees are back in India's limelight

The country's track record of dues-recovery based on personal guarantees for corporate loans has been poor. This could explain why Subhash Chandra's case is being watched so keenly

The ongoing controversy over Zee TV founder Subhash Chandra's personal liability under personal guarantees extended by him for loans taken by his Essel Group-linked firms has drawn into the limelight an arcane part of company law: the issue of personal guarantees in the context of credit extended to limited-liability companies, loosely referred to as 'corporates.' While the final outcome of the case is awaited, given the mind-boggling sums involved (with claims worth thousands of crores admitted), it is sure to put the role of personal guarantees and guarantors under greater scrutiny. Especially since a special bench of the National Company Law Tribunal has stayed an earlier NCLT order approving Chandra's ₹6.5 crore repayment plan and also restrained Chandra from selling or transferring property held by him, directly or indirectly, during the matter's pendency.

Section 5(22) of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), 2016, defines a 'personal guarantor' as an individual who stands surety for a loan taken by a corporate debtor and thus promises to pay or discharge the corporate borrower's debt in case of default. Part III of the IBC is clear about the liability of the guarantor. It goes by Section 128 of the Indian Contracts Act of 1872: "The liability of the surety is co-extensive with that of the principal debtor, unless it is otherwise provided by the contract." Further, a creditor can proceed directly against the guarantor to recover dues without first exhausting legal remedies or recovery options against the primary borrower. The rationale of taking a personal guarantee is to ensure that this person has some skin in the game. As this individual's personal assets—are

distinct from corporate assets—are exposed to liquidation for loan recovery in case the principal borrower defaults, s/he is expected to keep the business solvent. Moreover, unlike earlier, when creditors could begin insolvency proceedings only against a corporate debtor under the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) of the IBC, lenders can now also proceed against a guarantor while they pursue an insolvent company. Should the corporate IBC case be resolved, the guarantor's liability remains, so that any unrecovered portion can still be recovered from the promotor.

Indeed, to minimize scope for ambiguity, the IBC outlines a separate legal process for handling personal guarantors of corporate debt. While a company's insolvency is handled via the CIRP, a promoter's personal insolvency is governed by a distinct framework that is also adjudicated under the same roof—the NCLT. Over the years, jurisprudence in such cases has evolved substantially. In a landmark ruling—*Lalit Kumar Jain vs Union of India* (2021)—the Supreme Court of India firmly established that approving a resolution plan or completing the CIRP for a corporate debtor does not discharge a personal or corporate guarantor from legal obligations. It has since also been established (NCLT, Bengaluru) that proceedings against a personal guarantor under Section 95 of the IBC are independent and do not require a pending CIRP against the corporate debtor. Presumably, this is to guard against guarantors alienating their assets before a CIRP gets underway. Despite these judgements, the track record of recovery from guarantors has been poor, with most cases stuck in civil-court litigation. The Zee founder's case being so widely watched across the country shouldn't surprise anyone.

We have fewer state-run schools but that's no cause for any alarm

India's progress on schooling can't be measured by its school count. Here's what is really going on



ANURAG BEHAR
is CEO of Azim Premji Foundation.

Since a Niti Aayog report surfaced in June 2026, a familiar refrain has returned to public debate: nearly a lakh government schools have shut down over the past decade—proof, say critics, of the government abandoning public education and of the National Education Policy 2020 (NEP) working against the poor. The number is real. We have 94,000 fewer schools now than just over 1.1 million in 2014. The conclusion being drawn from it is not.

I say this having spent years observing the public education system and working with colleagues in these schools every day. The Azim Premji Foundation has close to 2,500 team members working directly with government schools across 63 districts in six states. They visit and work in nearly a lakh schools every quarter. In these districts, we have seen about 1,000 instances of what gets counted statistically as a school closure. In none of these cases has a child lost access to school, nor has it become significantly more difficult, while the quality of schooling has improved.

This is worth dwelling on because the attack seems so logical and its emotional appeal is so obvious (it suggests abandoned children) that we must resist emotive over-simplifications.

Almost all the closures we have observed on the ground fall into one of two categories and both are being read

in the same needlessly alarmist way.

The first is straightforward and common: two small government schools are within walking distance of each other, in the same habitation or adjoining ones, each too small to be run optimally. When one is closed, its children and usually its teachers move to the other, which also continues to serve the same children as before. Nothing changes for any child except that she now attends a school with more classmates and teachers and often a head-teacher who was earlier stretched thin across two campuses. Access for students does not get any more difficult as their school remains at walking distance after the merger.

The second is a more technical version of the same thing: two nearby schools are formally merged under a single management unit; this shows up as a 'closure' in the count, even though nothing on the ground actually shut down. The NEP is explicit that such rationalization must not compromise access, and in the cases we have observed, it has not. A spreadsheet cannot tell the difference between a school that vanished from a community and one consolidated with its neighbour, and much of the public conversation is being conducted at the level of the spreadsheet, not the lived reality.

Niti Aayog's own report can explain why states did this. India runs roughly five times as many schools as China for comparable enrolment; over 36% of our schools have fewer than 50 students. A small school cannot have subject-wise teachers even for subjects like language, math, science and social science, leave alone having teachers for art and physical education. Its physical resources are also limited. Teachers in such schools have to work in isolation and students do not get an important learning experience: of working with a number of peers. Consolidation is not neglect of the public system. It is an improvement.

The change makes teachers more effective, a part of the argument that critics rarely engage with. Consider a

teacher who earlier ran a small school alone: 25 children spread across five grades and three subjects, teaching everything to everyone, all day, with no one to share the load. After consolidation, that teacher may be one of two or three in a school of 50 students across the same five grades—more children learning within their peer group, and with work divided sensibly: one teacher takes languages across grades, another mathematics and science, a third the youngest grades. This is precisely what the NEP's emphasis on subject teaching and reducing the multi-grade burden is meant to produce. Three teachers each handling one subject well beats one teacher doing three subjects badly.

Not every closure everywhere in India has been handled well, admittedly. Nor does it mean oversights are unnecessary. Poor implementation is always possible and it must be watched for, especially in remote and difficult terrain. But the case being made by closure-data alarmists is not that specific implementation has faltered in specific places, it is a sweeping claim that school closures in themselves amount to an assault on public education and on the poor. That claim does not survive contact with the reality of classrooms and habitations.

What is happening, in the overwhelming majority of instances we have seen, is a slow and overdue correction: fewer, better-staffed, better-resourced schools replacing many small, thinly resourced, single-teacher ones. That this is being read instead as evidence of government apathy says more about the preconceptions people have than about what is happening in education.

The test of any such school system reform is simple: can every child still get to a functional school without difficulty and is the learning obtained better than before? On both counts, the evidence from the ground is reassuring. That evidence deserves at least as much attention as the number '94,000' being bandied about by critics.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

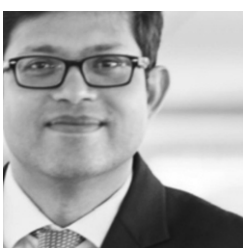
Creditors have better memories than debtors.

BENJAMIN FRANKLIN

THEIR VIEW

Do not let India's forex-reserve diversification slacken

DEEP MUKHERJEE



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Is there a twist in India's foreign exchange diversification tale? An International Monetary Fund (IMF) paper in 2022 identified India as among the major countries diversifying its forex reserves to non-traditional currencies. At 10% of its reserves, India's share of non-traditional currencies was at the same level as those of Germany and Switzerland, but below those of Indonesia, South Africa and France. By the latest count, India's forex reserves stood at \$729 billion. Foreign currency assets (FCA) made up 81.1% of these and gold 16.7%. Note that FCA includes foreign currency investments in Treasury bonds and the like, as well as deposits denominated in mainstream currencies such as the dollar, euro, pound and yen, plus others such as those of Australia, Canada and Sweden. Between March and August, India's forex reserves increased by 5.5% and its FCA by 7%. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), like many Asian central banks, does not publish currency-wise forex positions. However, it may be assumed that the

FCA increase was driven by dollar-denominated deposits by overseas Indians made with banks in the country to benefit from the special incentives on offer.

India's FCA fell from 94% of reserves in 2017 to 80% in March 2026, the lowest in 30 years, before rising to just over 81%. The concentration of dollars in India's reserves may have increased. The numbers suggest a detour from diversification. One hopes that RBI does not move away from its diversification agenda in the hope of supporting the rupee. Globally, most central banks, including of America's closest allies, are diversifying away from the dollar. While the greenback will remain dominant, US debt is no longer risk free; major global rating agencies do not consider it AAA level. Arguably, in an extreme global crisis, a diversified reserve base may be more beneficial than over-dependence on any single currency.

Who is eating into the dollar's share of reserves? In 2001, the dollar constituted 71.5% of the global reserves of central banks. This share fell to 57.1% by the first quarter of 2026 (IMF: *Currency Composition of Official Foreign Exchange Reserves*). Mainstream currencies, however, have not taken the dollar's share. The euro falters to deceive. In 2001, it formed 18% of global reserves and

surged to 27.7% by 2009 before retreating to 20% currently. Likewise, the yen's share has fluctuated between 4% and 6% since 2000. The pound has done surprisingly well with a slice of about 4%. It is the non-mainstream currencies that have gained prominence in global reserves. They have grown from 2% in 2000 to 13% currently.

Drivers of forex reserve composition: The ratio of FCA vis-à-vis gold and share of dollar holdings within FCA are mainly driven by two factors. *One*, the need for dollar liquidity; and *two*, a country's integration with the US, financially and geopolitically. High integration with the US financial system explains the high dollar holdings of the UAE and South Korea, for example.

Meanwhile, Türkiye, despite being a net importer with a structural need for dollar liquidity, keeps over half of its reserves in gold for geopolitical considerations. Germany, France and Italy, all net exporters and thus with limited dollar needs, have traditionally held large gold reserves. Gold's

share of their reserves have climbed from 60% to 80% over the last decade.

India, being a net importer, needs ample dollars for imports. Its integration with the US financial system is at best moderate and it is geopolitically positive to neutral in this context. So, while it needs dollar liquidity, it

must diversify too. This is not a de-dollarization drive but aimed at managing global financial market risks. Some of the US's closest allies have among the highest gold holdings or lowest dollar holdings.

Although RBI has successfully guided India through forex turmoil, some further considerations may be noteworthy.

Coverage re-map: India has moved way ahead of its 1991 balance-of-payments crisis days. Thus, high forex reserves need not make for a victory parade. They come with a cost and have diminishing marginal utility. We should stop looking at reserves as a cover for a varying number of months of imports. Let's look at them as a buffer for net imports, should India suffer the stress of, say,

Reducing our currency concentration risk would not be seen as an attempt at de-dollarization

crisis days. Thus, high forex reserves need not make for a victory parade. They come with a cost and have diminishing marginal utility. We should stop looking at reserves as a cover for a varying number of months of imports. Let's look at them as a buffer for net imports, should India suffer the stress of, say,



THEIR VIEW

What the World Bank's B-Ready survey could tell us about India

What we do with findings of this remade tracker of business conditions will matter more than the rank it assigns the country



TULSI JAYAKUMAR

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The World Bank's Business Ready assessment, B-Ready, will publish its findings on 101-plus economies this September. For the first time since its predecessor, the Ease of Doing Business (EoDB) ranking, was shelved, India's business environment will be measured against the rest of the world by an entity other than itself.

The World Bank discontinued its Doing Business survey in 2021 after an independent investigation found that senior bank officials had pressured staff to alter data in the 2018 and 2020 editions, most visibly to lift China's ranking. Azerbaijan, Saudi Arabia and the UAE saw their scores adjusted too. The rebuilt B-Ready, launched in 2024, is a methodology that leans less on expert opinion of what national laws say and more on what thousands of firms report actually happens to them. For India, this history matters. It means the exercise the country now faces has been redesigned specifically to close the loophole that discredited its predecessor, which makes a strong Indian showing worth more than a Doing Business ranking once was.

India boasts of strong macroeconomic numbers in 2026, with a 7.7% GDP growth rate last fiscal year (the fastest pace among the world's major economies), nominal GDP of \$4 trillion, inflation held within its target range, an import cover close to 11 months and a modest 1.1% current account deficit. Behind these numbers lies a decade of reform efforts by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), comprising seven editions of the Business Reforms Action Plan, over 9,700 state-level reforms, more than 47,000 compliances reduced and a national single window system linking approvals across three dozen states and central ministries. The change has been dramatic at the entry stage: a company can now be registered, tax-enrolled and bank-ready within a week through a single digital filing. Startup India has recognized over 185,000 new enterprises, most within days of their applying.

However, there is need for caution. The old Doing Business framework scored regulation largely as it was written, judged mostly by expert opinion on how good our laws looked on paper. B-Ready asks: does the written code match the practice? It pairs expert assessment with direct firm surveys, asking not just whether a rule exists, but whether business owners across tier-2/3 cities experience it the way it was intended. That is a higher bar, and even economies with strong reform reputations elsewhere have found it exposes gaps their own reporting had missed.

B-Ready also follows a firm through its entire life, covering location, labour, finance, trade, taxes



and what happens when things go wrong. This is where India's record thins out. Our courts have 50 million pending cases, a backlog that has grown roughly 80% in a decade; land and property disputes account for a striking share of it. Close to two-thirds of all civil litigation can be traced to who owns what piece of land. Parliament passed the Commercial Courts Act in 2015 precisely to speed up business disputes, aiming for court judgements within a year, but the implementation of its procedures has been uneven across states. Inaction is not necessarily to blame. Land-record digitization, a key enabler, has made real if patchy progress and dedicated commercial courts work well in a number of places. That unevenness, however, is what a firm-level survey is designed to catch.

These gaps cannot all be read as a failure of will. Land is a state subject under India's Constitution and the judiciary is rightly independent of the executive. No central ministry, however well-run, can legislate its way into the timeline of another branch of government or into the differing capacities of 28 states. The DPIIT's reform tools, from compliance reduction to digital platforms, are real instruments, but they were never designed to compel a court's pace or a state land administration's efficiency. Judged against what the DPIIT actually controls, its record looks impressive.

Lacunae at the ground level does not mean India should expect a poor showing on B-Ready overall, nor that the assessment will simply validate every

doubt. The country is likely to score high on 'business entry,' where digital systems genuinely deliver what they promise, and equally likely to fare poorly on 'dispute resolution,' where the gap between statute and courtroom reality has been documented by independent legal researchers for years, long before this exercise came along. A mixed, pillar-by-pillar result would not be an indictment of India's reform thrust. It would accurately reflect an economy where some parts of government can move quickly and others, by design, cannot.

Whatever September's numbers show, India's demographic clock provides a significant reason for policymakers to keep pushing regardless of the score. India's working-age population is projected to peak around 2041. We have perhaps 15 years in which our growth and workforce advantage will move in the same direction before the arithmetic turns against the economy. What matters is whether millions of workers who are still in low-productivity agriculture can actually move into better jobs. This is a shift that depends as much on functioning courts and clear land titles as on how quickly a business startup can be registered.

The World Bank's B-Ready should be taken as less a verdict than a mirror, a genuinely useful one, after six years without such a report card. What we do with what this survey shows will matter more than the rank itself.

These are the author's personal views.

MINT CURATOR

The Nepal tragedy highlights the value of big reservoir dams

Don't shun storage hydro projects that could help fend off disasters



DAVID FICKLING

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Development banks largely stopped funding hydro power in the 1990s.

PTI

In the popular imagination, there is only one threat to picturesque mountain landscapes that can compete with the destruction wrought by flood disasters like the torrent that swept through valleys on the Nepalese-Chinese border: dams. These concrete behemoths replace occasional catastrophic natural inundation with one that is permanent and artificial. Pristine river valleys disappear beneath reservoirs. Communities are forcibly relocated, their lives uprooted.

Those criticisms are true. But the events of the past week, with 955 dead and more than 4,000 still missing, should be a warning that the imagined counterfactual is false. Roads, tourism, trade and settlement are already transforming remote mountain communities. Meanwhile, warming is destabilizing the very soil on which homes are built and sparking disastrous floods. The question is whether development will include the infrastructure needed to manage increasingly volatile rivers.

The damage caused by some large dam projects is real. India's efforts to build a string of reservoirs on the Narmada River displaced hundreds of thousands of poor, tribal and low-caste families. That injustice sparked a movement that helped give hydro such a bad name that development banks largely stopped funding it in the 1990s.

In retrospect, this was a terrible outcome. Hydroelectricity is one of the few forms of generation to match the rock-bottom prices of wind and solar. When it is built with a storage reservoir, it also provides on-demand, zero-carbon electricity that can be stored from one month to the next. Such dams can also help control floodwaters that could do grievous damage to downstream communities.

A potent example happened in 2018 on the other side of the Tibetan plateau. After a landslide blocked part of the upper Yangtze River and formed a vast unstable lake, dam managers at six reservoirs downstream proactively dumped 1.3 billion cubic metres of water so they would have enough capacity to absorb an outburst flood. Along with other measures, that appears to have substantially reduced the damage done. Storage dams in Austrian river valleys in recent decades have reduced extreme water levels by about a third relative to their previous peaks, as per a 2022 study.

The withdrawal of funding from aid donors didn't stop hydro being built. With the World Bank sitting on the sidelines in the 1990s, China self-financed the Three Gorges Dam, the world's biggest power station. Africa's largest, the Grand Ethiopian

Renaissance Dam, was also largely paid for out of Ethiopia's meagre domestic budget amid objections from neighbours. Tanzania is now doing the same.

Nepal itself is going through a mini-boom, driven by private developers building run-of-river generators—a sort of water-wheel on a massive scale that cannot store significant volumes. About 90% of hydro in Nepal is this type, which provides little of the on-demand power or flood-control benefits of storage dams. The workers missing or rescued from flooded construction tunnels after last week's disaster were all building run-of-river plants.

The funding drought from multilateral donors has been persistent. Back in 2004, the World Bank argued the pendulum had swung too far against hydro and vowed to reverse this trend. Despite that, the sector has not benefited from a spending surge on renewable energy since.

Commitments for hydro comprised just 2.8% of energy funding by major development banks in 2022, the lowest share since 2009. Since the 2015 Paris Agreement, they have promised \$8.7 billion. Even fossil-fuel production and generation have done better, at about \$12 billion.

That's a perverse outcome. Hydro is likely being crowded out by more bankable solar, wind and battery plants, but the point of development banks is to finance projects that don't pencil out well in raw cashflow terms. It's hard to put a dollar value on the lives and livelihoods saved if a once-in-a-century flood can be prevented by the sort of water engineering rich nations take for granted. The benefits are nonetheless real.

Nepal's vast natural water resources and relatively small population should allow it to earn good money selling electrons to its energy-hungry neighbours. Yet, until 2023, it was importing more power from India than it was exporting. A transmission line to Bangladesh only went into operation last year. Even amid the current building boom, it has completed just 3.4GW of the 42GW of hydro capacity that's economically viable, with another 4.3GW under construction.

Will the next generation of hydro projects merely extract electricity with run-of-river dams? Or build storage dams that give downstream communities greater protection from the consequences of our increasingly deadly climate?

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THEIR VIEW

Think ahead: we must adapt insolvency to the age of AI

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Artificial intelligence (AI), Generative AI, Agentic AI and other AI tools are gradually being adopted by insolvency professionals to enhance productivity. The benefits of AI for claims processing, document summarizing, identification of financial anomalies and evaluation of resolution plans are self-evident, provided that the output of AI tools is put to critical human scrutiny. Companies are also adopting AI tools with gusto and assimilating them into their operations. This implies that in insolvency cases of the future, resolution professionals (RPs) will need to understand the AI tools used by insolvent companies. These technical skills may be either self-acquired or outsourced.

At the heart of India's Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) is a moratorium on any disruption of services essential or critical to a company. AI tools and the associated cloud infrastructure may qualify as one of the aforesaid services in future cases. These services must continue if regular payments

are made for the period under insolvency. A corporate will have AI services that are billed in advance as well as those that are billed with a lag.

Services billed in advance would include commitments such as reserved cloud capacity and pre-paid usage. Services billed with a lag may include charges for AI model interfaces, 'tokens' used by AI platforms, cloud computing beyond monthly quotas and sundry data processing services. However, what is the course of action if some lagging-bill vendors halt their services for non-payment of invoices predating the insolvency commencement date? Moreover, these vendors may be situated overseas, beyond the jurisdiction of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT); the operative legal provisions of cross-border insolvency are still awaited.

The RP is also tasked with duties, primarily taking control of the corporate debtor along with all its assets and determining its financial position. Herein will arise another challenge. The assets may comprise the corporate debtor's data and prompts running on a third-party AI platform. How does one segregate the two? And whose asset is the AI response generated? Further, bereft of the platform, for a valuer, what is the value of the proprietary data (unless one assumes the

interchangeability of AI models) that would yield similar output given the same inputs?

Another duty of the RP is to comply with every law. We are all aware of Nick Bostrom's 'paperclip maximizer' thought experiment, wherein, in a quest to maximize paperclip production, an AI system would pursue the goal so diligently that it would consume all of Earth's metal resources. In similar vein, if an AI agent tasked with quality inspection but trained to maximize profitability clears goods with slight defects, will the RP be liable for such a breach?

Avoidance transactions, those that are impermissible in law and deprive the corporate debtor of assets through shady means, are another issue that calls for attention. However, a deal that seemingly qualifies as an avoidance transaction but was undertaken in the normal course of business may fall outside its realm. In the case of a corporate debtor whose AI agent executes a transaction, would it be deemed to be one in the normal course of business, even though

the same transaction undertaken by a human may have been categorized as probable avoidance? Further, what if its counterparty is also an AI agent? Surely, *prima facie*, this would be in the normal course of business. But what if agentic models have been trained unfairly by manipulation of model

weights? Thus, an RP must understand how an agent has been trained to act, which may be difficult to fathom even in an ideal scenario as it would require access to training data, structured metadata, input context, reasoning chains, alternatives considered and audit trails.

Liquidation and the distribution waterfall too will face new questions. A liquidation order is a notice under which employees and workers are discharged. Could an AI model vendor, for example, stop supplying services on the argument that an AI agent was part of the firm's workforce? Also, what will such an agent qualify as under the liquidation waterfall: worker, employee or vendor?

As AI tools proliferate in the world of busi-

ness, the aforesaid issues and others currently beyond imagination, will come to the fore. Thus, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI) and relevant regulators should come together to study potential scenarios and devise appropriate solutions.

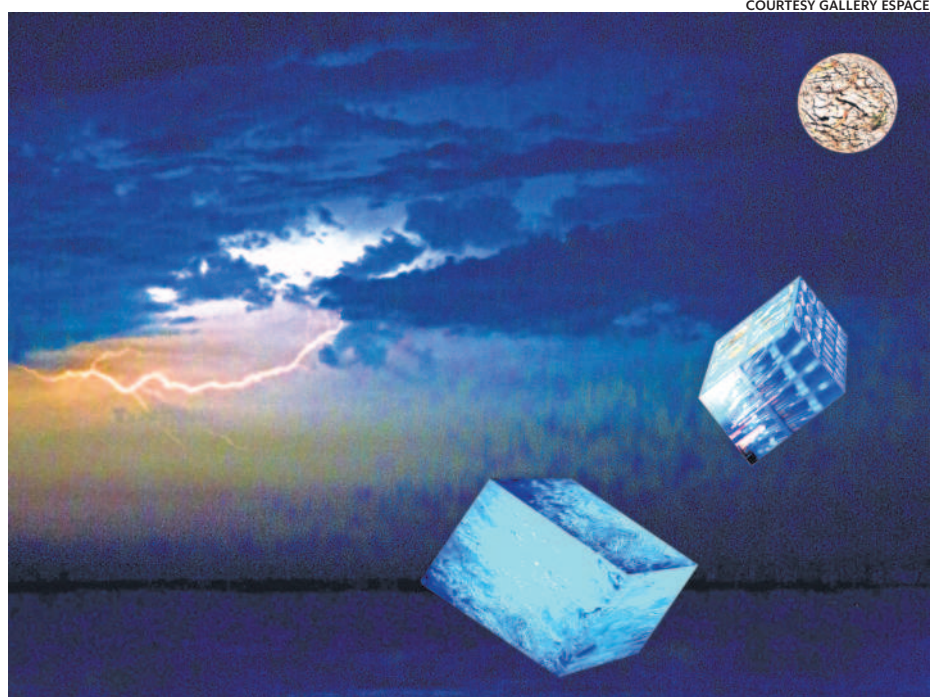
The ministry of corporate affairs is in the process of developing an Integrated Platform for Insolvency Ecosystem (IPIE) that is designed to assimilate all stakeholders of the insolvency ecosystem. Going a step further, in conjunction with the National Financial Reporting Authority, it could mandate auditors to audit and report on AI tools used by corporates. This information should remain confidential but may be accessible to an RP in the event a company is admitted to insolvency; although the IBC requires a service provider of the corporate debtor to extend cooperation to the RP, a database would be a quicker means of action.

Finally, the Indian legislature and IBBI would do well to hold wide-ranging stakeholder conversations, not only within the insolvency ecosystem but also with technologists who are well versed in the subject of AI adoption by India Inc. If we fail to adapt IBC processes to the AI age, grey areas will provide fertile ground for litigation, with concomitant delays to the process.

India mustn't let grey zones created by this technology's adoption get in the way of resolutions



DCAW 2026 tackles ecology and memory



COURTESY GALLERY ESPACE



COURTESY LATITUDE 28

The ninth edition of the Delhi Contemporary Art Week focuses on ecological and social realities and their impact on our collective psyche

Abhilasha Ojha
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This year has brought with it news of several natural disasters, be it the floods in Assam, Kerala and Uttarakhand or the devastation in Nepal. In such a scenario, the reading of many of the artworks at the ninth edition of Delhi Contemporary Art Week (DCAW) becomes even more pertinent, centred around themes of climate, ecology, memory, place and identity. The annual fixture in the Capital's art calendar continues to spotlight contemporary art practices from India and South Asia, highlighting six women-led galleries—Blueprint12, Exhibit 320, Gallery Espace, Latitude 28, Shrine Empire, and Vadehra Art Gallery.

Besides individual gallery showcases, DCAW, spread across three buildings of Bikaner House and on view till 5 September, includes two curated exhibitions. *Bye Bye Monsoon*, curated by Adwait Singh, brings together 18 artists to celebrate a synergy between Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement: Climate Change and the Unthinkable* and visual art. The book, which looks at a tornado that struck Delhi in the 1970s, became Singh's anchor to commission artists to create works that "distinctly situated views on climate exigencies from across the subcontinent".

"Extreme weather is increasingly becoming part of our everyday experience even as we continue to struggle with how to understand and represent it," says Singh. What's interesting is how the weather is metaphorically represented in the artworks to signify not just the geographical

climatic conditions but also historical, material and environmental conditions that have brought us to the present times.

This Animate Earth, curated by Annalisa Mansukhani, builds on conversations related to the destabilisation of flora and fauna, especially in context of the recent Ken-Betwa Link Project, the redefining of hills by the Supreme Court in relation of the Aravallis, and protests centred on the threat to the forests of Hasdeo Arand by coal mining projects.

On display are artist Chameli Ramachandran's renditions of flora, which she has been painting for decades, Bakula Nayak's compelling mixed media on vintage paper showing creepers and flowers merging with and emerging from human figures. Bhikari Pradhan shows the angst and pressures on farmers, reflecting on what ails agrarian practices in contemporary times.

DEPICTING THE HUMAN CONDITION

Jaimini Jariwala's textile work is almost autobiographical, rooted in Surat, a textile city that has shaped her work. Her process, featuring cloth and thread, has evolved over time. Part of Exhibit 320's showcase, Jariwala's works, along with 10 other artists, engage with the issues related to urban landscapes, ecological memory, gendered labour, migration, craft, and displacement.

Another interesting display is Blueprint12's *Ways of Being Seen*, bringing together 10 artists working across painting, sculpture, photography, textiles, ceramics, drawing, and printmaking. They look at how human beings navigate emotions to understand identity. Aparneet Mann, for instance, takes *phulkari*, the traditional embroidery of Undivided Punjab, to create installations on wire mesh that evoke nostalgia. Then there are paintings by artist JK, that dwell on queer identities in the urban space. While offering a sense of intimacy, the works also question the claustrophobia of our surroundings.

Across DCAW, one can see the curatorial stance lean towards climate change, identity and artistic experiments. A stark example of this is Deena Pindoria's acrylic artwork printed on handwoven *kota* fabric, with its square-check



COURTESY BLUEPRINT12

khat pattern, showing how the material can be experimented with. Similarly, Juhikadevi Bhanjdeo *Skin of Home*, a fascinating series showcased by Latitude 28, uses dyed cotton fabric and safety pins arranged in a repeating pattern to reflect acts of self-mending.

EXPERIMENTS WITH MATERIALITY

At Shrine Empire's showcase, the gallery's co-founder Anahita Taneja points to a newly commissioned work, *What the River Remembers*, *Must the Stones Forget?*, done by Chris

(Clockwise from above) Ravi Agarwal's *Cosmic Flash*; mixed media work by Bakula Nayak; and Shubham Kumar, *Fragile Beauty II* (set of 4).

Besumatery. It uses oil pastels on corrugated aluminium sheets to show the gushing river carrying with it stones and silt. The mind immediately goes to recent videos showing the overflowing glacial lakes in Nepal. The artist probably looked at the river for its beauty, but for the viewer, the imagery can also be synonymous with destruction. Sangita Maity's *Changing Course of the River* offers similar food for thought as a set of 30 artworks in copper make us look at water bodies and their sources from a new perspective.

Climate change also needs to be seen in the context of communities, personal histories and the fragility of natural resources. In that context, work by Smitha M. Babu, being showcased by Vadehra Art Gallery, stands out. The artist revisits matriarchal lineages, women-led labour, and ecological connections to mark the relationship between people, land, and sea. Anju Dodiya's *Studio Fragments*, previously presented at Frieze Masters, London, is also on display at the gallery's booth.

FINDING PERSONAL HISTORIES

Nandini Bagla Chirimar's work carries a profound sense of maternal warmth. As part of Gallery Espace's exhibit 'Presenting Abundance', the artist's work is informed by her mother's memories, especially her collection of saris, which Chirimar often saw hanging or folded in closets. The artist creates, through her mixed-media work—pencil, woodblock, watercolour, collage, and hand-extracted stone pigments on Japanese handmade *kaji* natural paper—a complete journey into her inner landscape.

According to Bhavna Kakar, co-founder of DCAW, and founder and director of Latitude 28, what makes DCAW even more exciting this year is the galleries' willingness to show work that may not necessarily have a commercial leaning but is high on experimentation. Ultimately, the ninth edition of DCAW is more than a display of artistic skill; it is a mirror held up to a region in flux. By tackling ecological grief, personal histories, and material experimentation, the participating artists turn abstract crises into deeply felt human stories.

Abhilasha Ojha is an independent art writer.



Venice kicks off with Rupert Murdoch film

Danny Boyle's *Ink* is one of the hottest titles at this year's Venice Film Festival

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George Clooney and Danny Boyle are helping kick off the Venice Film Festival in style Wednesday on the Lido. Clooney, a festival mainstay, is receiving a lifetime achievement award, while Boyle is premiering *Ink*, his film about Rupert Murdoch's acquisition of the British tabloid *The Sun* in 1969.

Over the course of the next 11 days, the festival will see many stars from Hollywood and beyond grace the red carpet, from Robert Pattinson to Noel and Liam Gallagher of Oasis, but the focus this year seems to be more on geopolitics than movie star moments. The sprawling lineup includes documentaries about the conflict in Gaza (*Naza*), Elon Musk (*Musk*) and independent Russian journalists covering the war in Ukraine (*My Undesirable Friends—Part II: Exile*) as well as Palestinian films and a short about U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement in Minneapolis.

The festival's director Alberto Barbera said most of the films they saw during the selection process dealt with "contemporary problems."

"We didn't really have a choice," he said. "We are in a space open to everybody for discussion, for confrontation. Everybody is completely free to express themselves."

Much attention has also been placed on the fact that there is only one film directed by a woman among the 21 competing for its top prize, the Golden Lion. "It's a big problem, of course," Barbera said. "I'm completely aware of the fact that there is a lot to do to give women the place that they deserve in cinema."

He explained that while the organizers saw many interesting films from women, and programmed many in the festival's sidebars, they didn't find films that were strong enough for the main competition. Barbera also said the festival is on the side of women in their battle for equal representation.

Some of the films premiering at Venice could emerge as Oscar contenders, including opening-night film *Ink*, a competition title starring Guy Pearce as Murdoch and Jack O'Connell as editor Larry Lamb. The film is an adaptation of James Graham's acclaimed play.

Boyle earlier this year said he made *Ink* in the same way he made *Trainspotting*—they didn't have much money, but they had a committed ensemble who rallied behind the idea and a breakout star. In *Trainspotting*, that was Ewan McGregor. In *Ink*, he said, it's O'Connell.

The festival will also get its Clooney moment when he receives a Golden Lion for Lifetime Achievement.

"We decided to give him a Golden Lion because in a way he suffers from his own image, you know the seductive man, an image of beauty and so on," Barbera said. "Sometimes people forget that he is a great actor, one of the greatest actors at the moment and a great filmmaker."

The world champions you've probably never heard of

A new book shines an important spotlight on Paralympic stars and traces the journey of para sports in India

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A world champion from Haryana, an exponent of javelin throw in his prime years who has revolutionised the discipline in India. If you're thinking Neeraj Chopra, you're not entirely wrong. But what if there's another athlete who fits the bill and—surprise, surprise—is more decorated than Chopra?

Sumit Antil's rise has been spectacular and in tandem with Chopra's over the last few years. Consecutive gold medals at the Paralympics (2024 and 2020) and the reigning world champion in the javelin F64 event, which he's won thrice so far. In May, he rewrote his own world record in Bengaluru; in fact, he's done it on over 10 occasions now.

Take some time to reflect on it, the domination of an athlete who is often left to compete against himself. And who is relentless in his pursuit to raise the bar each time he steps out on the field.

Antil and Chopra are both 28 years old and gold medal prospects at the Para Asian and Asian Games, respectively, in September-October. And yet, there's a certain disparity in the way the two are known—one a household name, the other not quite. *India's Paralympic Revolution* by Boria Majumdar, Trisha Ghosal and Rohan Chowdhury is a timely reminder on why athletes like Antil deserve to be celebrated as well.

The numbers present a clear picture. Over the last three editions, Indian athletes have picked up 15 medals at the Olympics and 52 medals at the Paralympics. Chopra and Abhinav Bindra are the only two individual Olympic gold medalists (eight were won by the men's hockey team). The Paralympians have won 15 individual gold medals since Muralikant Petkar's first in 1972. At the Paris Paralympics in 2024, India placed 18th in the overall tally with 29 medals, their most successful campaign till date.

It wasn't always this way. In the past, para athletes were often left to fend for themselves. For instance, Devendra Jhajharia had to sponsor his trip to compete at the Athens Paralympic Games in 2004; he returned with gold in spite of the meagre resources at his disposal. It was only then that the government recognised the Paralympic Committee of India. For long, these athletes were invisible to the rest of



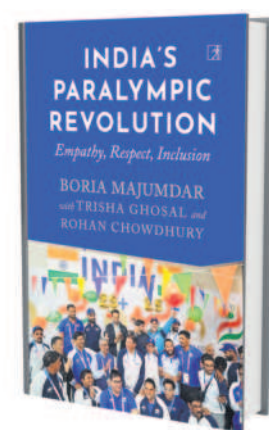
Sumit Antil at the Tokyo 2020 Paralympic Games.

GETTY IMAGES

the world, immersed in their routine and striving for excellence, never short on talent or belief.

Things have rapidly changed over the last few years, whether it's their inclusion as part of the government's Target Olympic Podium Scheme or through private funding. Once access to gear and training

was on par with the demands of a professional athlete, it made it easier for them to chase their goals. More importantly, they realised there was someone interested in their progress, backing them to succeed. And when Jhajharia was awarded the Khel Ratna in 2017, it was clear that their gold was as good as anyone else's.



India's Paralympic Revolution: By Boria Majumdar, Trisha Ghosal & Soumyajit Das Chowdhury; Simon & Schuster India, 304 pages. ₹699

Majumdar and his team have spent many hours on ground witnessing this transition. Long after the media jamboree departed from the Olympic Games, they settled in to watch the para athletes take centre stage. The poise of teenaged archer Sheetal Devi while challenging her experienced opponents. Or Antil's insatiable appetite to better his own mark with every throw, competition or not.

They exchanged notes with the likes of Jhajharia and Deepa Malik, who once

waged lonely battles as athletes but now fiercely back the current lot. They observed the efforts of dedicated coaches like Gaurav Khanna and Kuldeep Vedwan, who have made it possible for a generation of these athletes to dream by just being in their corner at all times.

The book traces the journey of some of the star performers alongside that of para sports in India. The accounts could have been more detailed and better structured. Repetitive facts and trivial details sometimes make it a tedious read.

Overall, though, the book draws attention to an integral part of Indian sport that has been long ignored. For anyone indifferent to para sports until now, here's a start to catch up with everything that's happened of late. To gain an understanding of just what it took for India to graduate from a lone Paralympic medal in 2012 to 29 medals at Paris 2024. And why there's a lot more to look forward to from Indian para athletes in the time ahead.

That kind of public interest may require a different mindset in a country where a majority celebrates their athletes once in four years. The change can begin with the Para Asian Games in September. Is it possible to look beyond disabilities, and truly believe that if Chopra is worth raising a toast to, so is Antil.

Shail Desai is a freelance writer based in Mumbai.